

## IN BRIEF



### Not a single paper leak in Punjab: CM amid Oppn. attack

**CHANDIGARH/SANGRUR**  
Fending off criticism from the Congress, Akali Dal and BJP over "paper leaks" in poll-bound Punjab, CM Bhagwant Mann on Sunday said not a single case of paper leak had come to light during AAP's four and a half years in power. » **Page 4**

### BJP using unfair means ahead of bypoll: Kishor

**PATNA**  
Ahead of the Bankipur bypoll scheduled for July 30, JSP founder and bypoll candidate Prashant Kishor on Sunday accused the BJP of harassing his party leaders and deploying Jeevika Didis for election campaigning. » **Page 12**

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EDUCATIONPLUS » **PAGE 5**

# Nilekani to lead high-powered task force on exam reforms: PM

It will recommend steps to make exam system leak-proof and technology-driven; former ISRO Chairman Somanath, IIT-M Director Kamakoti among members; Pralhad Joshi takes charge as Union Education Minister, chairs review meeting

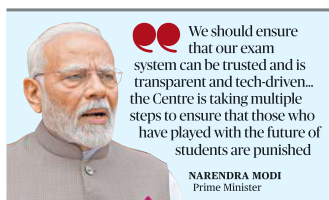
**Nistula Hebbar  
Maitri Porecha**  
NEW DELHI

**P**rim Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday announced the constitution of a high-powered task force, to be headed by former UIDAI Chairman Nandan Nilekani, to recommend steps to make the country's examination system leak-proof and technology-driven.

The announcement came a day after former Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan resigned following widespread protests over the NEET paper leak and subsequent re-examination.

Meanwhile, Union Minister Pralhad Joshi on Sunday officially took charge of the Ministry of Education at Kartavya Bhavan. Mr. Joshi, who also holds the portfolios of Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution, and New and Renewable Energy, chaired a meeting of the Ministry to review the implementation of various schemes and other initiatives.

"We should ensure that our exam system can be trusted, and is transparent and tech-driven. Under the



We should ensure that our exam system can be trusted and is transparent and tech-driven... the Centre is taking multiple steps to ensure that those who have played with the future of students are punished

**NARENDRA MODI**  
Prime Minister

leadership of renowned technology expert Nandan Nilekani, a high-powered task force will be formed, which will focus on exam reforms," Mr. Modi said in a video posted on Instagram. "The Centre is taking multiple steps to ensure that those who have played with the future of students are punished. We have already announced the formation of fast-track courts. We are bringing a stringent law in Parliament on Monday," he said.

**'Compromised image'**  
Responding to the announcement, Congress general secretary (communications) Jairam Ramesh said the Centre was yet to implement the K. Radhakrishnan Committee's 101 recommendations after the 2024 examination

leaks. "This is ultimately only a high-powered attempt to fix the *Pradhan Mantri's* irretrievably compromised image," he said in a post on X.

The multidisciplinary panel of domain experts will help revamp the National Testing Agency's examination system, especially from a technology perspective, sources said, adding the committee under Mr. Nilekani will consist of former ISRO Chairman S. Somanath, former IB Director Tapan Deka, IIT-Madras Director V. Kamakoti, former Education Secretary Anita Karwal, and logistics expert Amrit Lal Meena.

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**RELATED REPORTS ON**  
» **PAGES 10 & 11**

## Rahul questions Shah over 'barbaric assault' in Delhi

**Sandeep Phukan**  
NEW DELHI

Seeking accountability for the "barbaric assault" on students during the march in Delhi on July 20, Rahul Gandhi, the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, has asked Union Home Minister Amit Shah whether he had authorised the use of "lethal force". In a letter

written to the Minister, the Congress leader noted that the students were demanding a fair education system. But, instead of being heard, security forces assaulted them with indiscriminate force and lethal weapons, he said, also noting the alleged use of pellet guns.

**FULL REPORT ON**  
» **PAGE 11**

## Tejashwi demands release of protesters held in Bihar

**Amit Bhelari**  
PATNA

Lashing out at the Bihar Police for the arrest of hundreds during a State-wide bandh on Saturday, the State's Leader of the Opposition, Tejashwi Yadav, on Sunday called for the immediate release of students, Opposition MLAs, and

other protesters, including his elder brother Tej Pratap Yadav.

He warned the State government that more people would hit the streets once again in protest, if those held are not released within 24 hours.

**FULL REPORT ON**  
» **PAGE 10**

## Centre warns Indian seafarers about jobs in 'volatile' Black Sea

**Kallol Bhattacharjee**  
NEW DELHI

The External Affairs Ministry on Sunday issued an advisory urging Indian seafarers to "carefully assess security risks" before accepting jobs on commercial ships that operate "in and around the Black Sea and adjoining maritime areas", citing increasing drone and missile attacks on ships in the region that remains highly volatile due to the ongoing conflict between Russia and Ukraine.

Earlier, the Indian Embassy in Ukraine said it was "closely monitoring" the situation after a projectile hit the *MV AGN Ragmar* in Ukraine's Black Sea port of Odesa on Saturday. The ship employed four Indian seafarers, of whom two have been found to be safe while information about the other two is still awaited.

There has been an increase in the number of such incidents since April, resulting in the deaths of five Indian seafarers, the Ministry said. "Indian nationals intending to undertake employment on commercial vessels operating in or transiting the conflict-affected region are advised to carefully assess the prevailing security risks before accepting such assignments," the Ministry said



The Ministry of External Affairs has cited increasing attacks on ships in the region. FILE PHOTO

in its advisory, noting the security situation in the region and around the Black Sea and adjoining maritime areas. "Commercial vessels operating in or transiting these waters are facing significant security risks, including missile and drone attacks," it said.

The Ministry urged Indians to follow a set of precautions, such as obtaining "comprehensive information from employers/recruitment agencies and ship operators regarding the vessel's intended route, ports of call, security arrangements, and emergency response procedures". The "terms of employment" should "comply with applicable maritime standards and provide adequate provisions for medical care, evacuation, repatriation, and compensation in the event of an emergency," it said.

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### KARNATAKA TRANSITION Siddaramaiah bows out of poll politics

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### WILL OF THE PEOPLE Youth at the vanguard The resoluteness of the student protests forced the government to step back

EDITORIAL » **PAGE 6**



### SOORYAVANSHI SPARKLES India beat Zimbabwe for a 3-0 series sweep

SPORTS » **PAGE 15**

## Dialogue with Pakistan will only be on PoK: Rajnath

**Saurabh Trivedi**  
NEW DELHI

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Sunday said the success of Operation Sindoor demonstrated India's capability to respond to every "misadventure" by Pakistan with overwhelming force, while reiterating that there would be no dialogue with Islamabad except on Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK).

Addressing the 27th Kargil Vijay Divas commemorations at the Kargil War Memorial in Dras, Mr. Singh asserted that PoK is an integral part of India under Pakistan's illegal occupation and warned that any attempt to undermine India's sovereignty would invite a decisive response from the armed forces.

"The success of Operation Sindoor is proof that India possesses the capability to respond to Pakistan's every misadventure with a severity far beyond its imagination," he said, adding that India no longer distinguishes between terrorists and the governments that support them.

The Defence Minister also accused Pakistan of making terrorism a part of its state policy.

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## Mirabai makes it a golden day for India; Rishikanta clinches a silver

**K. Keerthivasan**  
GLASGOW

Weightlifting has always been one of the disciplines that has contributed significantly to India's tally at the Commonwealth Games. The fact that the country has won as many as 33 medals in the last three editions underlines the vital role of the weightlifters.

On Sunday, the opening day of the weightlifting competition here, Indians once again made their presence felt by winning two medals — a gold and silver.

Hours after Rishikanta Singh Chanambam finished second in the men's 60kg category, Mirabai Chanu produced a golden moment in the women's 48kg class. For the latter, it was her third successive Commonwealth Games yellow metal after Gold Coast (2018) and Birmingham (2022).

Surprisingly, the 31-year-old had a shaky start to her snatch sequence, missing the opening attempt at 82kg. She, however, remained unflustered and returned to successfully lift the weight.

The lifter from Manipur went on to clear 85kg on her third visit, establishing



**Manipur's day out:** It was triple delight for Mirabai while Rishikanta (below) became the first male lifter from the State to win a medal in the Commonwealth Games, PTI

ing a new Commonwealth Games record much to the delight of the Indian fans at the venue.



After failing to clear 105kg in her first clean and jerk attempt, Mirabai managed to overcome the challenge in her second try and finished with a total of 190kg, both new Games marks. Ruth Asuquo Nyong of Nigeria won silver with a total lift of 168kg while Irena Jane Henry of Malaysia clinched bronze with 167kg.

**Growing tally**  
Earlier, Rishikanta won India's second medal at the Games with his silver. The 28-year-old began the snatch series with 116kg, increased it to 119kg and eventually

produced a 121kg lift. In clean and jerk, the Manipur lifter passed the 143kg test but failed in his next two attempts at 148kg and 151kg. Rishikanta finished with a combined lift of 264kg.

Malaysia's Mohamad Aniq Kasdan won the gold with a total lift of 273kg, setting a Games record. Kasdan also registered a new Games high in clean and jerk with 152kg.

Kenya's Joshua Amunga Moby was the other podium finisher, thanks to his overall effort of 264kg (snatch: 121kg; clean and jerk: 143kg).

**MORE REPORTS ON**  
» **PAGE 15**

## Iran says it is halting 'retaliatory strikes' on U.S.

**The Hindu Bureau**  
CHENNAI

Extending the weekend lull in fighting in West Asia, with the United States having halted operations after 13 days of strikes, Iran announced on Sunday that it too was halting its operations.

Iran's Army spokesperson Mohammad Akraminia was reported as saying: "Since our strategy has essentially been retaliatory, we have also halted our retaliatory operations."

On Sunday, Iran's Tasnim news agency claimed that a tanker exploded after it hit a mine while transiting the Strait of Hormuz through a route Tehran had not approved. The news agency had made a similar claim about another tanker on July 23, adding that two other tankers had refrained from crossing the Strait after that incident. While bodies that assess maritime threats, such as the United Kingdom Maritime Trade Operations, did not confirm these explosions, they have nevertheless warned of heightened risks from mines in the Strait.

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**IRAN SLAMS UKRAINE ATTACK**  
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## 2 die in Noida sewage tank; contractor arrested

**Press Trust of India**  
NOIDA

Two persons died of suspected asphyxiation in a sewage treatment plant tank at a residential housing society in Noida's Sector 150 on the intervening night of Saturday and Sunday, the police said.

According to the police, Shashikant Sharma, 40, entered the tank to clean it but lost consciousness. Akash, 22, a security guard, entered the tank to rescue him and also collapsed. Both were taken to a hospital, where they were declared dead.

The contractor, Manoj Jain, has been arrested and booked in the case.

## Six-year-old drowns in pit; one arrested

**Press Trust of India**  
NOIDA

A six-year-old boy drowned after falling into a water-filled pit dug for boring work in Kaladham Colony in Greater Noida on Saturday, the police said.

The incident took place when the child was playing near the pit around 7 p.m., police said, adding that the child was rushed to a nearby hospital but was declared dead on arrival.

A case was registered based on a complaint by the victim's family, and the contractor of the project was arrested on Sunday.

# Student groups aim to carry Jantar Mantar momentum into DUSU polls

Multiple outfits maintained a visible presence at the protest site during the 36-day-long agitation; AISA says it will centre election campaign around issues raised at the protest; working for campus reforms, were present where needed: ABVP

**Ashna Butani**  
NEW DELHI

With the Jantar Mantar protest drawing to a close, student organisations are preparing to shift their campaign from the protest site to the Delhi University (DU) campuses as the new academic session begins on Tuesday.

The networking, visibility, and political momentum built during the 36-day agitation at Jantar Mantar, led by students and the Cockroach Janta Party over the NEET paper leak case, are likely to shape their outreach ahead of the DU Students' Union (DUSU) elections. The polls are due to be held six to eight weeks after the commencement of the session, in accordance with the Lyngdoh Committee guidelines.

Multiple student organisations maintained a visible presence at the protest



AISA leader Anjali said the organisation intends to tap into the resistance and understand what caused so much anger. FILE PHOTO

site through tents and help desks. Leaders of the All India Students' Association (AISA) emerged as prominent faces during the hunger strike. Volunteers from Aam Aadmi Party's (AAP) Association of Students for Alternative Politics, the Kartikruti Yuva Sangathan, and the Students' Federation of India helped manage logistics.

The Congress-backed National Students' Union of India (NSUI) publicly

joined the protest after the alleged police violence during the July 20 protest march to Parliament. The only prominent student organisation absent from the site was the Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP), which said it was working for campus reforms and was present where it "needed to be".

Anjali, an AISA leader and DU student, said, "Some of the most important issues in the country

were raised at Jantar Mantar. We will definitely centre our DUSU campaign around those issues."

AISA intends to "tap into the resistance and understand what caused so much anger", she said.

NSUI national president Vinod Jakhar said, "We did not get permission at Jantar Mantar, so we supported the movement from behind the scenes."

Sources in AAP said its students' organisation would contest the election this year. "There is a lot of anti-BJP sentiment among students," a source said.

Meanwhile, the ABVP argued that it had been equally active on the issue of educational reform.

"We conducted the first major NEET protest and were looking at solutions beyond a resignation. We were thinking practically, not politically," an ABVP member said, requesting anonymity.

## DU extends deadline for candidates to accept seats

**The Hindu Bureau**  
NEW DELHI

The University of Delhi (DU) on Sunday extended the deadline for candidates allotted seats in the second round of undergraduate admissions to accept their offers.

Colleges have been asked to verify and approve applications by Tuesday. Candidates will have time till Wednesday to accept their seats.

Officials said the extension was granted in view of the additional workload on colleges, which are set to conduct orientations as the academic session begins on Tuesday.

## Outstation students lament fewer holiday spells in DU this year

**Navya Jain**  
NEW DELHI



Delhi University has reduced festival breaks in its new academic calendar. FILE PHOTO

For Delhi University students from outside the city, academic breaks are often the only window to travel home. But with a tighter academic calendar and fewer extended holidays in the new session, many said they are finding it difficult to plan trips around classes, assignments, and attendance requirements.

The newly issued academic calendar has drawn criticism for providing limited breaks during major festivals. The week-long Deepavali break has been removed, with a holiday only on the day of the festival, which falls on a Sunday this year. For Navratri, which begins on October 11, holidays have been granted only from October 18, covering Ashtami, Navami and Dasara.

The winter break is scheduled from December 25 to 31 - seven days - with the even semester beginning on January 1, 2027, leaving little time for students to travel, celebrate, and return. "For students coming from far-off States, this is not practical," said Arnav Vaid, a BCom student at Hansraj College from Jammu and Kashmir. "With ticket prices so high, we cannot spend ₹10,000 to ₹15,000 for a break of just five to seven days."

**72 holidays this year**  
According to the academic calendar, the total number of holidays stands at 72 days this year, compared to 71 days last year. However,

students note that in practice, holidays are often reduced. In the 2025-26 session, although 71 days were scheduled, students effectively received 53 days due to extended examinations and delayed breaks.

University officials, however, said the calendar has been framed in accordance with University Grants Commission norms. "There have to be 90 teaching days per semester, which we are following," an official said.

A faculty member involved in preparing timetables, speaking on condition of anonymity, said provisions exist to revise holidays later. "There is one day for Deepavali now, and more days might be added later as the university has the provision to do so. This is done later in the year after examination days are calculated," the faculty member said. Since the Common University Entrance Test became the basis of admissions in 2022-23, delays in the NTAE-led process have pushed back sessions. In 2022, undergraduate classes began in November, nearly three months later than usual.

## New chiefs for women's, minorities commissions

**The Hindu Bureau**  
NEW DELHI

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Sunday appointed former Municipal Corporation of Delhi councillor Lata Gupta as Chairperson of the Delhi Commission for Women,

filling a vacancy of more than two years.

Former East Delhi Mayor Nirmal Jain was appointed Chairperson of the Delhi Minorities Commission. Mr. Jain is the first non-Muslim to head the commission since it was constituted in 2000.

## 46% city schools found deficient in 'Child Safety Checklist' audit

**The Hindu Bureau**  
NEW DELHI

Nearly 46% of the 1,677 schools inspected in Delhi were found to have safety deficiencies under the 'Student Safety Checklist', with 774 schools flagged for gaps, Lok Niwas offi-

cials said on Sunday.

Of these, 270 of 790 government schools, 463 of 812 private schools, and 41 of 75 aided schools were found to have deficiencies, with private schools accounting for the higher share overall. The drive, launched after a July 6 re-

view meeting, will continue until all 5,633 schools are covered across the city.

The checklist covers physical, emotional, social, emergency and cyber safety, with schools asked to take corrective steps followed by verification to ensure compliance.

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CM K

## PERSONAL CHANGE OF NAME

I, **GOVIND Kumar** Dahal s/o Late Premal Ghimre born on 01/03/1980 c/o P. Moulding Part - 2, Leimakhong, Kangpokpi Dist., Manipur-795002, have changed my name to **Prakash Ghimre** vide affidavit dated 23/07/2026 at Kangpokpi, Manipur.

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IN CONSUMER COMPLAINT NO. WCC/142/2017  
INDERDEEP SINGH ARNEJA & ANR  
...Complainant/Debtors Holders  
Versus  
M/S. TODAY HOMES & INFRASTRUCTURE PVT. LTD. & ORS.  
...Opposite Party/Judgment Debtor

By Order of the Hon'ble National Consumer Disputes Redressal Commission, New Delhi.

**NOTICE**  
(Service By way of Publication)  
Whereas Execution Application No.242 of 2021 in the above Consumer Complaint No.1428 of 2017 has been filed by the Debtors Holders namely, M/s. Inderdeep Singh Arneja & Anr. S/o Mr. Gaurav Singh and M/s. Gaurav Singh Arneja & Anr. S/o Mr. Gaurav Singh, both R/o: 34D, BW Block, Shalimar Bagh, New Delhi-110028, through its counsel Mr. Inderdeep Singh Arneja, Advocate and Solicitors, Office at D-16, Ground Floor, Patel Nagar Extension, New Delhi-110017, M/s. 782134601, 9688012952 & 961108807 before the Hon'ble National Consumer Disputes Redressal Commission, New Delhi.

2. The Execution Application No.242 of 2021 in the above Consumer Complaint No.1428 of 2017 filed on 02.07.2024 at 10.30 A.M. is pending for disposal.

3. Whereas it has been brought to the notice of the Hon'ble National Consumer Disputes Redressal Commission that the Notice has remained unavailed upon the above mentioned Judgment Debtor No.2 in the normal course.

4. As per the Hon'ble National Consumer Disputes Redressal Commission, while directing for substituted service of the notice to the Judgment Debtor No.2 by way of publication in atleast two leading newspapers, one in English and one in local language of the area where the Judgment Debtor carries on his business, has posted the matter for further hearing on 08.07.2024 at 10.30 A.M.

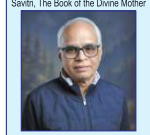
5. Accordingly, the above mentioned Judgment Debtor No.2 is hereby directed to attend the hearing in the above Execution Application No.242 of 2021 in the above Consumer Complaint No.1428 of 2017 filed on 02.07.2024 at 10.30 A.M. in person or through an authorized representative counsel failing which the case will stand dismissed and determined in the Hon'ble National Consumer Disputes Redressal Commission.

Dated this 16th June, 2026 at New Delhi.  
By Order  
Dr. Parvati Kumar Singh (Registrar)

## OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

### DEATH

"Alone her hands can change Time's dragon base,"  
Savithi, The Book of the Divine Mother



**VENKATASUBRAMANIAN ANANTHANARAYANA (AVS)**  
(1953 - 2026)

AVS alias "Rajamam" reached his heavenly abode on 19 July 2026 in Dallas, Texas.

*He is lovingly remembered by*  
Karpagam (Wife), Koushika (Son), Archana (Daughter-in-law), Raksha (Daughter), Saran (Son-in-law) and Grandchildren.

Isha, Anagha, Ahana and Aarohi Forever in our hearts.

### DEATH ANNIVERSARIES



**Mr. P.B. Balasubramanian**  
22.06.1952 to 22.07.2026

We fondly remember our beloved Father, Late Mr. Balasubramanian, whose vision, integrity, and unwavering dedication laid

the strong foundation of BASE Automation Technologies. His principles continue to guide us, and his legacy lives on in the values we uphold and the work we pursue each day. Though he is no longer with us, his influence remains deeply embedded in our journey and will continue to inspire generations to come.

We offer our heartfelt tributes, remembering him with profound respect and enduring gratitude.

Fondly remembered by  
The family members and employees of BASE Automation Technologies Pvt. Ltd.

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**DEATH**

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**LATHA REDDY**  
1951 - 2026

Ambassador Latha Reddy served India with exceptional distinction as a diplomat, rising to become Secretary (East) in the Ministry of External Affairs and later Deputy National Security Advisor, where her wisdom and strategic vision left an enduring mark on the nation's foreign and security policy. She will be remembered by family and friends for her genuine love, kindness and grace.

Viewing: July 27th 2026 (9.30 - 11.00 AM)  
591, 3rd Main Road, Sadashivanagar, Bengaluru 560080  
Cremation at Hebbal Crematorium at 12 noon

**Vani Reddy & KC Raja Ram, Vijaya Chandru & Uma  
Rukmini V Reddy, Arathi & Alok**



## States

## Timings

## DELHI

|                    |       |           |
|--------------------|-------|-----------|
| MONDAY, JUL. 27    |       |           |
| RISE               | 05:40 | SET 03:16 |
| RISE               | 17:56 | SET 03:14 |
| TUESDAY, JUL. 28   |       |           |
| RISE               | 05:41 | SET 19:15 |
| RISE               | 18:38 | SET 04:09 |
| WEDNESDAY, JUL. 29 |       |           |
| RISE               | 05:41 | SET 19:14 |
| RISE               | 19:17 | SET 05:07 |

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| Safdarjung    | 37  | 28  |
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## Shivakumar to convene MPs' meet in Delhi on State issues

The Hindu Bureau  
BENGALURU

Karnataka Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar has called for a meeting of all Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha members from Karnataka in New Delhi on Monday to discuss the State's pending proposals before the Centre and seek bipartisan support for securing Central assistance during the ongoing Monsoon Session of Parliament.

The meeting will be held at Karnataka Bhavan, with all MPs from the State having been invited.

Speaking to presspersons in Bengaluru on Sunday, Mr. Shivakumar said the meeting would focus on issues concerning Karnataka's development and the need for MPs to collectively pursue them in Parliament.

## Siddaramaiah calls time on career in electoral politics

Former Karnataka CM says he will not contest the 2028 Assembly election but will continue to serve people and the party; the year marks 50 years of his political career. Congress leader says

The Hindu Bureau  
MYSURU

Former Karnataka Chief Minister Siddaramaiah has announced his retirement from electoral politics, while asserting that he will continue to remain active in public life and work for the Congress and the people.

Addressing a gathering during the 86th birth anniversary celebrations of former Speaker, the late 'K.R. Pe' Krishna, at K.R. Pet town in Mandya district on Saturday, the veteran Congress leader said he would not contest the 2028 Assembly election. However, would remain



Turned down: Siddaramaiah declined the party's offer of a Rajya Sabha seat, saying he is not interested in national politics. ANI

active in politics.

The announcement came after supporters urged him to remain in electoral politics for another decade.

He had also declined the party's reported offer of a

Rajya Sabha seat, saying he was not interested in national politics.

'Polluted politics' Later, in a Facebook post on Sunday, Mr. Siddaramaiah said the changing

nature of politics had influenced his decision.

"Politics has become polluted. Therefore, I have decided not to contest the 2028 Assembly election. However, I will remain active in politics, stay with the people and continue to support them," he said.

Recalling his political journey, Mr. Siddaramaiah said he entered public life in 1978 as a member of the Taluk Board and would complete 50 years in politics in 2028.

"I have witnessed victory and defeat, but I have never compromised on my ideology or betrayed my conscience. That gives me immense satisfaction," he said.

## Jeevan Jyoti vision centres strengthen rural eye care in Alwar

Mohammed Iqbal  
ALWAR

New vision centres established at government health facilities in the rural areas of Rajasthan's Alwar district under the Jeevan Jyoti Project have strengthened eye care services for villagers.

The initiative has embedded timely and effective services within the existing public health system.

Opened under Sightsavers India's rural eye health programme, the vision centres - staffed with trained optometrists - are being utilised for door-to-door eye screenings and counselling for the early detection of cataracts and refractive errors. Those living in remote villages in the district receive timely diagnosis and treatment.

The project has led to the establishment of vision centres at Community Health Centres (CHCs) in the Ramgarh and Laxmanagar blocks. Besides bringing essential services closer to local communities, these centres provide eye screening, refraction services, identification and referral of cataract cases, and dispensing of near-vision glasses free of cost.

In collaboration with the district administration, each vision centre has been staffed with a qualified optometrist and equipped with key instruments.

Babul Yadav, Medical Officer in-charge at Ramgarh CHC, said spectacle prescriptions were generated on site and transportation facilities arranged to take cataract patients to



People being apprised of eye care services at an outreach programme in Alwar district. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

and from the treatment centre. "The ophthalmic assistant placed at the hospital helps us deliver better eye care services. Additionally, the team goes door to door to encourage people to seek treatment," he said.

## Community outreach

In the project's community outreach component, a total of six community mobilisers, three in each block, carry out screening and refer patients to the vision centres for further assessment. About 54,000 door-to-door screenings have been conducted so far.

Kishan Devi, 64, a resident of Ramgarh, said the sight in her left eye had been restored through the Jeevan Jyoti Project.

"Earlier, everything appeared dark and I even fell once, injuring my knees. After the surgery, I can see clearly and manage all my household work with ease," she said.

These efforts by the voluntary organisation have led to a two-fold increase in footfall at the CHCs for eye care services.

## Sitting MLAs among Kerala leaders facing sexual abuse charges

Deborah Thambi  
KOCHI

Indian Union Muslim League (IUML) leader and former legislator M.C. Kamaruddin, who has around 120 cases pending against him, tops the list of people's representatives facing criminal proceedings in Kerala.

Mr. Kamaruddin was one of the accused in the Fashion Gold Jewellery in-

vestment fraud of 2019. He was booked by invoking the provisions of the Banning of Unregulated Deposit Schemes (BUDS) Act, 2019. Five people's representatives - Kovalam MLA M. Vincent, former Kazhakkuttam MLA M.A. Vaheed, Thrissur MP Suresh Gopi, former Parassala MLA A.T. George, and Kunnathunadu MLA V.P. Sajeendran - are reportedly facing sexual harassment charges.

## Revanth to speak to Rahul over opening doors of Parliament, Assembly to Gen Z

R. Ravikanth Reddy  
HYDERABAD

Proposing a new slogan - "Jai Jawan, Jai Kisan and Jai Yuva" - Telangana Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy has said that the country should be ready to channel the energies of the Gen Z (demographic group born roughly between 1997 to 2012) and give them more political opportunities.

He will take the first step towards this by proposing to Congress leader Rahul

Gandhi a reduction of the age for entry into the Legislature to 21, Mr. Reddy said in an informal chat with the media here on Sunday.

He said that the issue would be discussed with Mr. Gandhi and AICC president Mallikarjun Kharge during his visit to New Delhi on Monday.

Mr. Gandhi would be requested to discuss this with the INDIA bloc partners and other parties, the Chief Minister said.

The Telangana govern-

ment would pass a resolution in the Assembly in August this year, he said, adding that in Parliament, the Opposition could explore the opportunity to introduce it as a Private Members' Bill to put pressure on the ruling party.

Mr. Reddy further said that several seniors in his party were in tune with his idea of passing a resolution in the State Assembly in August.

"We will send the resolution to the Centre so that

the proposal could be discussed along with the proposed Delimitation Bill, Women's Reservation Bill and the enhancement of Lok Sabha seats."

"If needed, the proposal could also be referred to a Joint Parliamentary Committee for consultations," he said.

"Mr. Modi can no longer depend on one-way communication like with his 'Mann ki Baat' on radio. He also has to listen to the country's voice."

MARUTI SUZUKI

NEXA

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## States

## IN BRIEF



## Take note of 'irregularities' in JPSC exam, Champai urges HC

BJP leader Champai Soren on Sunday urged the High Court to take suo motu cognisance of alleged irregularities in the Jharkhand Public Service Commission (JPSC) and Jharkhand Staff Selection Commission examinations and order a CBI probe into all recruitment processes conducted by the two panels over the last few years. The former Chief Minister, in a social media post, said those "toying with the future of the youth" should not receive government protection but instead harsh punishment. He expressed doubts over the impartiality of the investigation by the State CID. **PH**

## Dipke sparked revolution, must get security, says Sena Minister

Maharashtra Minister and Shiv Sena leader Sanjay Shirsat on Sunday expressed pride that Abhijeet Dipke, founder of the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) and resident of his Aurangabad West Assembly constituency, had sparked a revolution and deserved security. Mr. Shirsat was speaking to reporters after visiting Mr. Dipke's family in the Waluj MIDC area of Chhatrapati Sambhaji Nagar. Mr. Shirsat said Mr. Dipke, who is yet to return home despite the CJP calling off its protest, must be given security. "His parents were worried because every parent wants their kids to remain safe," he said. **PH**

## Not a single paper leak case under AAP govt. in Punjab, says CM amid Oppn. attack

Cong. seeks State Education Minister's ouster over 'repeated paper leaks'; in Phagwara, Haryana CM calls out 'serious lapses', repeated leaks; youth protesting for jobs clash with police in Sangrur

Press Trust of India  
CHANDIGARH/SANGRUR

Ending off criticism from the Congress, Shiromani Akali Dal and Bharatiya Janata Party over "paper leaks" in poll-bound Punjab, Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Sunday said, "We have been in power for the past four and a half years. Not a single paper leak has happened in Punjab."

Addressing an event in Zirakpur to honour 882 government school students who cleared the National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (NET) re-exam recently, Mr. Mann said only one case of cheating had come to light during his tenure and that the police had dismantled a "highly sophisticated, inter-State cheating racket" operating during the recently held Pharmacy Officer exam.

Hitting out at the Mann government, State Congress president Amrinder Singh Raja Warring said,



CM Bhagwant Mann, AAP's Manish Sisodia at an event to felicitate govt. school students who cleared NEET, in Mohali on Sunday. ANI

"While Dharmendra Pradhan has been forced to resign as the Union Education Minister, Punjab Education Minister Harjot Singh Bains is still in office. He must also go for repeated paper leaks in Punjab."

Haryana CM Nayab Singh Saini also hit out at the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) government, accusing it of "betraying" the youth by failing to ensure transparency in recruitment exams. Referring to the recent Excise Inspector

recruitment examination, the senior BJP leader, who was addressing a function in Phagwara, alleged that the results reflected "serious irregularities", with selected candidates carrying names such as "SBI", "GIPS" and "Photo".

He also criticised the Punjab government over the "leak" of the recent Pharmacy Officer paper. The Haryana CM alleged that "repeated incidents of paper leaks amount to a betrayal of talented and

hardworking youth" aspiring for government jobs.

## March to CM's house

Meanwhile, clashes were reported in Sangrur on Sunday between youth protesting under the banner of 'Berozgar Sanyukt Morcha', who were trying to march to the CM's residence, and police personnel. The protesters, who have been staging a sit-in outside the Deputy Commissioner's office, began their march with banners demanding government jobs and the fulfilment of their pending demands.

The police placed barricades on the route leading to the CM's house. A scuffle broke out when the youth tried to move past the barricades. Some protesters sustained minor injuries while a few participants, including women, reportedly fainted at the protest site. Leaders of the outfit said they will continue the stir until the government accepts their demands.

## U.P. CM takes on SP in Etawah, Mainpuri; reaches out to youth

Press Trust of India  
ETAWAH/MAINPURI/AGRA

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath took on the Samajwadi Party (SP) in its strongholds of Etawah and Mainpuri on Sunday, where he addressed the youth and inaugurated development projects worth over ₹1,200 crore.

At a function in Etawah, the home district of the late SP founder Mulayam Singh Yadav, the CM held the previous SP government responsible for tarnishing the district's image through nepotism and poor governance. "The youth of Etawah no longer face an identity crisis. Wherever they go, they receive the same respect as people from any other district," Mr. Adityanath said after inaugurating and laying the foundation stones for 128 development projects worth around ₹604 crore for Etawah, Jaswantnagar, and Bharthana Assembly seats. He also distributed certificates to beneficiaries of various government schemes.

In Mainpuri, represented in the Lok Sabha by SP chief Akhilesh Yadav's wife Chimple Yadav, Mr. Aditya-



U.P. CM Yogi Adityanath in Mainpuri on Sunday. ANI

nath said, "There was a time when people used to get frightened by the name of Mainpuri. Today, if a youth, a farmer or a trader from Mainpuri introduces himself anywhere in the country, people are eager to show him respect."

He also laid foundation stones for 111 development projects worth about ₹682 crore for Mainpuri and Karhal Assembly seats.

## 'Fight misinformation'

At a separate event in Agra, the CM urged teachers and educational institutions to play a "proactive role in combating misinformation" and guide students towards credible sources, warning that social media is being used to spread "hated" in society. U.P. is set to go to polls next year.

## Palaniswami, ex-AIADMK MLAs to appear before Speaker on July 30

The Hindu Bureau  
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu Assembly Speaker J.C.D. Prabhakar has asked AIADMK general secretary and party floor leader Edappadi K. Palaniswami and four former party MLAs, who are facing disqualification proceedings under the provisions of the Tenth Schedule of the Constitution, to appear before him on July 30.

In a letter sent from the Assembly Secretariat to Mr. Palaniswami, Assembly Secretary R. Santhi said the Speaker had called four

former AIADMK MLAs — Maragatham Kumaravel (Maduranthangam), P. Sathiyabama (Dharapuram), S. Jeyakumar (Perundurai), and Esakki Subaya (Ambasamudram) — to appear before him individually between 11 a.m. and 12.30 p.m. on July 30, allotting each of them 30 minutes. The Speaker also asked Mr. Palaniswami to appear before him during the same time.

## Disqualification plea

This was pursuant to a disqualification petition submitted by Mr. Palaniswami on May 13, after 25 rebel

AIADMK MLAs voted in favour of the Chief Minister S. Joseph Vijay-led Tamil Nadu Government during a vote of confidence in the Assembly. Later, Mr. Palaniswami condoned 21 of the 25 MLAs, while the four other members resigned from the Assembly and joined the TVK.

During the inquiry into the disqualification petition, the four former MLAs appeared before the Speaker separately on two occasions. Later, the Speaker sought clarifications from Mr. Palaniswami.

## Not shifting to national politics, says Fadnavis

Press Trust of India  
NAGPUR

Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Sunday dismissed speculation about him shifting to national politics.

According to sources, Mr. Fadnavis made a quick trip to the national capital on Saturday and later returned to Nagpur amid speculation about his possible shift to national politics against the backdrop of Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation as the Union Education Minister.

Asked by reporters in

Nagpur about his visit to Delhi, the Chief Minister said, "Today, I am in Nagpur and will be going to Mumbai in the evening. I am in Mumbai and Maharashtra only."

Meanwhile, Deputy CM Eknath Shinde on Sunday claimed that people have defeated the Opposition's alleged attempt to use students' protests to create unrest in the country. "The Opposition tried to exploit the emotions of students for political gain, but the [Narendra] Modi government delivered justice through action," he said.

## Bengal CM meets kin of victims of Sundarbans trawler capsized

The Hindu Bureau  
KOLKATA

West Bengal Chief Minister Suvenudh Adhikari on Sunday met the families of the victims of the Sundarbans trawler capsized earlier this month and announced several steps for better disaster management preparedness in coastal areas.

At least 11 fishermen died while four went missing after a trawler from Purba Medinipur capsized on July 8. The vessel lost communication soon after setting off and remained missing till it was traced by



Suvenudh Adhikari

the Coast Guard on July 14 at Bangher Chawki Island in the Sundarbans.

Soon after the incident, Prime Minister Narendra Modi announced ex gratia of ₹2 lakh each for the kin of the victims. On July 22, Mr. Adhikari also an-

nounced ex gratia of ₹5 lakh each and a civic volunteer job for one eligible member from each of the families of the victims.

"Many such incidents took place earlier but then the government never cared about them. Our government did. We feel that it is our responsibility," the CM said on Sunday.

## 'Efficient officers'

In view of the "poor status" of the coastal police stations, Mr. Adhikari declared that efficient officers will be appointed in those stations immediately.

## SPOTLIGHT

## Rahul Karmakar

Almost six decades ago, the Brahmaputra devoured Pashan Ali's house at Charai Khasara village in southwestern Assam's Goalpara district. Now, a legal hurdle in the land through which the river flows is threatening to erode his grandson Aminul Hoque's Indian citizenship.

On February 28, 2019, Aminul's world came crashing down when the Foreigners' Tribunal (FT) No. 4 in Guwahati adjudged him a non-citizen. The 38-year-old had been staying in a rented house at Borbori, a rural area on the outskirts of Guwahati, working as a daily-wage labourer when the police came knocking in 2016. Later, he told the court that the investigating officer referred his case to the FT the following year "without fair or proper inquiry".

Created under the Foreigners Act, 1946, the FTs are Assam-specific quasi-judicial bodies set up to address cross-border migration, prevent infiltration, and enforce the provisions of the 1985 Assam Accord, which ended a violent anti-foreigner agitation from 1979-1985.

One of the key provisions is to detect and detain suspected illegal immigrants who entered the State after March 24, 1971,

and deport them. Such people, detected by personnel of the Assam police's Border wing or those marked 'D' (doubtful) by the Election Commission are referred to the FTs.

"Aminul was lost after the FT judgement. His family challenged it in Gauhati High Court, but he was shocked that he, the youngest sibling, was the only member of his family to be deemed a foreigner," Khoiruddin Mollah, a family friend and a trader based in Lakhimpur, a block headquarters in Goalpara district, says. He adds that Aminul was scared when, last year, news broke of people possessing valid documents being pushed into Bangladesh.

After the Brahmaputra eroded his land, Pashan Ali moved to Dobakura with his family in the 1960s. In 1973, he purchased a plot at Ghugudoba, about 4 kilometres away, where his son Mohiruddin and his family shifted. The land, according to the documents submitted, measured 2 bighas, 1 katha, and 5 lessas. In Assam, 10 lessas make a katha, equivalent to 2,880 square feet, and 5 kathas make a bigha.

The Ghugudoba plot is on the northern bank of the Jinjiram, a Meghalaya-origin river almost as "land-hungry" as the Brahmaputra, which it meets after flowing for 120 kilometres. Later, the family moved to Hashdoba, about

## Eroding identities of Brahmaputra's children

Across Assam, decades of govt.-issued records are failing the citizenship test before Foreigners Tribunals and the Gauhati High Court as spelling variations, age mismatches, and shifting residences come under scrutiny



Among the documents Aminul Hoque submitted to the HC against the order declaring him a foreigner was the deed of a land near the Brahmaputra, which eroded his grandfather's first house. RITU RAJ KONWAR  
Real Creator IAS Edition <https://t.me/+8B98m5PQC8F4MmQ9>  
3 kilometres away from Ghugudoba.

The original land purchase deed was one of 15 documents Aminul submitted to the High Court in his defence. The Bench of Justice Kalyan Rai Surana and Justice Shamima Jahan did not find the deed and the other documents convincing enough to establish Aminul as an Indian citizen. The other documents included the 1951 National Register of Citizens (NRC) featuring the names of

came Mahruddin Sheikh, Mohiruddin, and Mohir Uddin; his mother Foziron Nessa featured as Nesa Khatun and Nesaton Bibi; and his grandfather Pashan Ali Sheikh became Pashan Ali, Pashan Ali, and Pashan Sheikh.

The court noted that the FT took into account the 1979 voters' list, which contained nine names. Two of them — Joshimuddin and Ashiya Khatun — were not proved to be Pashan Sheikh's family members.

The tribunal also found discrepancies in the ages of some family members: Foziron Nessa was 25 years in the 1979 voters' list, but 29 in the 1985 list (as Nesa Khatun). Moreover, the name of one of the six siblings of Pashan Ali, whom Aminul named in his oral testimony was missing from the 1989 electoral rolls, while the 1997 voters' list had three members — his parents and brother Fozir Ali.

Aminul left Guwahati to work elsewhere in the country after the High Court upheld the FT judgement on June 30. His acquaintances have a hunch that he could be either in Arunachal Pradesh or Meghalaya, possibly working in the hazardous coal mines that offer higher wages and a certain degree of anonymity.

Mahmud, Aminul's lawyer, cited the case of Dhubri district's Sirajul Hoque, whom the Supreme Court set free in February 2019, two years after two English letters — 'f' and 'm' — sent him to a detention camp in eastern Assam's Jorhat. An FT in Dhubri had declared him a foreigner in 2017 because of a mismatch in his grandfather's name, which read Kematullah in some documents and Kefatullah in some others.

"A large number of documents that the Supreme Court accepts in various cases are surprisingly disbelieved by the High Court

and the FTs for minor discrepancies. In the Sirajul judgment, the apex court observed that minor discrepancies in names and ages, and the shifting of residence do not constitute a major offence," Mahmud says.

## Documents rejected

What Aminul experienced a few weeks ago, Mohela Khatun of Darrang district went through in September 2019 when the 27 documents she submitted failed the citizenship test in the High Court. One of these documents was a certificate issued by the Deputy Commissioner of Darrang on February 15, 2013, certifying her as an elected panchayat member.

The FT-4 in Mangaldai, the headquarters of Darrang district, rejected all the documents, including a copy of the 1951 NRC featuring her "projected" grandparents. They also rejected a school transfer certificate from Japiya Government-aided High School in Bongaigaon district post-marriage to Jaidev Islam No. 3 Dhoipur village in Darrang district.

The FT-4 said these documents were "liable to be discarded" as they failed to establish her linkage to her father, shown as Abdul Kader of Japiya village and Abdul Kader Mandal of Barachala village, both in Bongaigaon district, in different documents. The FT-4 also rejected the docu-

ments connecting her to Desaruiddin and Asiran Bibi, whom she claimed to be her grandfather and grandmother, declaring her to be a foreigner.

Mohela, now 46, served two years at a detention centre as a declared foreigner. Out on bail, she filed a review petition at the High Court in May 2025, seeking a re-examination of the order upholding the FT-4 verdict.

"We exhausted almost all our resources in contesting this case, so much so that we have to think twice about visiting our lawyer in Guwahati (about 60 km southwest of Dhoipur)," her husband, resigned to a long haul, says.

## Tough legal fight

Like Mohela's husband, Rukia Begum is bracing for a tough legal fight to prove that her husband Mainuddin Ahmed, a Hindi teacher at the government-aided Nanglichar Middle English School near Mangaldai, is a citizen. Ahmed was sent to the Matia centre on June 29 after the designated FT declared him a foreigner despite the submission of 26 documents, including his appointment letter. "We are challenging the FT verdict in the High Court. Let's see how far we can go to establish him as an Indian," his wife says from their house at Nijnagajan village in Darrang district.

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## EDUCATIONPLUS

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K. Alamelu

## A missing link

Why Social Sciences research must connect to societal and real-world issues

India's doctoral research ecosystem in Social Sciences is in urgent need of a structural overhaul. While doctoral scholars in other countries are evaluated on working prototypes and real-world applications, the Indian system remains wedded to voluminous dissertations and the pressure to publish in so-called peer-reviewed or indexed journals.

## Problems

The mandatory publication requirement has lowered the quality of research and spawned an entire ecosystem of predatory and cloned journals that exploit desperate doctoral candidates who pay hefty sums to get their papers published. The publishing landscape has undergone a damaging inversion: where journals once paid scholars for their contributions, today scholars pay for the privilege of being published. Even more troubling is the exploitation by supervisors, ranging from demands to ghostwrite papers under the supervisor's name to performing domestic errands and, in extreme cases, being asked to pay to complete research within stipulated deadlines.

Universities themselves are not free of blame. Administrative delays plague doctoral candidates from the mo-

ment of registration up to thesis adjudication and result publication. In one reported incident, a Teacher Association had to intervene just to clear procedural formalities and resolve the reasons behind a delay.

The contrast with the Sciences is stark. Doctoral students collaborate on lab experiments, co-develop working protocols, create patentable products, and contribute to joint intellectual property.

Social

Science scholars, meanwhile, work in relative isolation on topics chosen less for societal relevance than for administrative compliance, completing research that is rarely tested against real-world rigour.

## Revamp needed

A resurgence in the research environment in Social Science requires regu-

latory bodies to ensure that universities are linked with the society around them. A mandatory academia-industry link for research and adoption of higher education institutes by industries can lead to research projects that address the problems that these companies face.

The departments of Pedagogy, Adult Education,

and Lifelong Learning can be directed to focus on issues such as curriculum design challenges, the integration of Artificial Intelligence in teaching and learning, and the development of scientific student assessment tools. By maintaining direct links with government departments and organisations working with child welfare, the Departments of Special Education and Rehabilitation can look at early identification of differently-abled children and their integration into mainstream life.

The Economics Department can work with district, state, and national planning bodies to prepare annual plans meant for optimal allocation of government resources. Data collection through field research and the analy-

sis involved are routine aspects of research. Grassroots issues like farmer distress or problems of informal workers can be an area of collaborative research with Labour Commissions, State Finance Commissions and so on. So far, only a handful of institutions such as Gokhale Research Institute and the Madras Institute of Development Studies have made a mark in the national planning bodies. Creating a link with governmental organs can help Economics departments transform shelf-bound research into a mutually beneficial societal endeavour. Departments of Sociology, Social Work, Psychology and Philosophy can establish links to local bodies, prisons, juvenile homes and NGOs working in rehabilitation and child protection to address and find solutions to social problems.

The doctoral theses that result from India's current research system often lie in archives, unread, unapplied, and of no use to the stakeholders in whose name they were ostensibly written. This is a systemic failure of purpose. The missing link between academia and society must be not only established but made mandatory in every university. Only then will India's doctoral degrees reflect the rigour and relevance that the nation's investment in higher education demands.

Views expressed are personal

V. Manickavasagam is Advisor, IQAC, and K. Alamelu is Director- IQAC and Senior Professor at the Department of Banking Management, Alagappa University.

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## IELTS update

IDP Education has announced that IELTS in India will transition from IELTS on Paper to IELTS on Computer from September 2026. The IELTS on Paper will be available in India until August end.

From September 2026 onwards, candidates in India will be able to choose from two options. IELTS on Computer will have the Listening, Reading

and Writing sections on a computer. IELTS on Computer (Writing on Paper) allows test takers to complete the Listening and Reading sections on a computer, while completing the Writing section on paper.

The Speaking test will continue to be conducted face-to-face with a certified IELTS examiner for both modes. For more information on the changes, visit [ieltsdpindia.com/](http://ieltsdpindia.com/)

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# Editorial



## Youth at the vanguard

The resoluteness of the protests forced the government to step back

A government that does not bend to the will of the people risks being broken. The resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan as Union Education Minister, after a sustained agitation by youth led by the satirically named Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), is more than just a ministerial casualty of the "paper leaks" scandal. It is a seminal moment in the unravelling of what political scientists describe as the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)-dominant party system in Indian democracy, which allows little elbow room for a fragmented Opposition. Entrance examinations are the gatekeeping mechanism that determines which young Indians get to enter the narrow but reassuring world of formal employment later on, in a country where most work remains in the grinding unorganised sector. Repeated leaks across several examinations have turned an apparatus for testing merit into one of widespread graft. Close to 20 lakh candidates were made to take the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test (Undergraduate) again after grueling preparation that coincided with their school examinations. Several students did not survive the ordeal. The grievance bound youth across castes and religions, the very identities that political mobilisation in India has been confined to in recent years. Bypassing a television establishment largely aligned with the ruling dispensation, the faceless protesters built support on social media within days. The high-handedness of the Delhi police and the attempts to throttle the Internet and mobility around the protest venues only swelled their ranks. The government eventually found that this agitation could not be crushed, swayed, split, distracted or left to dissipate, as others have been over the past 12 years. It was forced to negotiate, and in the face of the CJP's rightful stubbornness, Mr. Pradhan's continuation became untenable. The nothing-to-lose desperation of the protesters gained a political halo that came from their non-alignment with electorally focused established parties. This was a movement that could not be hijacked or undermined by the political elite, whether of the Opposition or of the government.

But Mr. Pradhan's announcement of his resignation does not inspire confidence. Instead of accepting moral responsibility for the failures in the conduct and the marking of various examinations, he tactfully sought to present his stepping down as an attempt to prevent "anti-national" elements from exploiting the situation created by the protests. Evident in his resignation letter is the government's mindset that sections of the students were acting against the Indian state with ulterior motives. This is also part of the same narrative that prompted the Delhi Police to meet the protesters with shock batons, pellet guns, and lathis with nails. The police actions were nothing short of calculated brutality that violated all protocols of crowd control. The resignation is a tactical retreat on the part of the government, not a realisation of mistakes made; it came after the abject failure of efforts to paint the protests as communal, as inspired by foreign agencies, and as designed for political mileage. Among the several missteps, the government first acted as if the social media followers were made up of mostly bots who would vanish from view if their accounts were withheld, then as if their virtual presence would have no real-life consequences, and finally as if they could be fought off with Instagram reels. Only on encountering failure after failure did the government get Mr. Pradhan to sign off. But, commendably, the protesters withdrew the agitation once their demands were met.

In the days ahead, the impact of the protests will be far wider than what the government hopes to restrict it to. Over the years, the Narendra Modi-led BJP government has converted mostly narrow electoral victories – a plurality of votes yielding a majority of seats, singly or in coalition – into expansive mandates. It has used them to break the constitutionalist consensus on settled questions of secularism and federalism, advancing a unitary, majoritarian agenda by creeping degrees. It has simultaneously raised its floor of support by radicalising sections in the north, west and now the east of India on the communal plank, which has in turn helped secure its legislative strength. It has recast dissent as anti-national or separatist and hollowed out the Opposition through induced defections and selective deployment of enforcement agencies. Combined with the pusillanimity of other institutions, including a passive judiciary, this has led to what many describe as a managed democracy living under an undeclared emergency for civil liberties. A nation born of non-violent struggle has needed, more than once since Independence, a non-parliamentary convulsion to turn its institutions back towards the vision of the freedom-fighting generation that framed the Constitution. The CJP, and those who stood with it – Sonam Wangchuk fasted for 26 days – have shown that a just demand, pressed through the quintessentially Indian route of satyagraha, can outlast the state's brutality and move an inflexible government to action. This is a lesson for the institutions charged with checking the executive, and for those charged with questioning authority, especially the media, which – barring some notable exceptions – have mostly played a negative role. They must play their constitutionally mandated and socially responsible role rather than give in to browbeating or expediency. Whether they do so will be tested as the government sets about reforming the entrance examination system with a different Minister in charge. What is certain is that India is yearning for change and rejuvenation.

# Do not surrender to China, do not depend on the U.S.

A volatile political climate in Washington has triggered a wave of strategic anxiety in New Delhi. Buffeted by the transactional, often erratic policy shifts of the Donald Trump administration – which hit India last year with punitive tariffs on steel and aluminium, stripped its preferential trade status, and aggressively renewed ties with Islamabad while imposing irritants such as tightening H-1B visa rules – a growing chorus of domestic voices is calling for a fundamental reset of India's China policy.

## Economic actors, their flawed line

The argument, championed largely by an influential business lobby, suggests that India's confrontational approach toward Beijing was overly synchronised with Washington's strategic agenda of "containment" rather than India's national interests. The lobby contends that because India remains deeply reliant on Chinese technology, supply chains, industrial inputs, and capital, a dogmatic anti-China stance ultimately stifles domestic economic growth while barely denting Beijing's economy. The core risk, critics warn, is Washington's historical pattern of tactical flip-flops – escalating tensions one day and striking bilateral deals the next – which risks leaving an overextended India strategically vulnerable to Chinese retaliation.

While the warning against subordinating Indian interests to an unpredictable Washington is entirely valid, it is not clear that this is what is occurring. In any case, the proposed alternative – a hasty, unreciprocated economic embrace of China – is a dangerous prescription. It mistakes tactical business convenience for long-term national security. A premature capitulation to Beijing ignores a decade of unprovoked hostility, deepens an asymmetric dependency, and strips India of its leverage just as the global order enters its most volatile phase since the Cold War.

Let us face it: the primary domestic driver for a China reset is an influential business lobby obsessed with short-term balance sheets. For years, parts of corporate India have argued that access to cheap Chinese capital, machinery, and active pharmaceutical ingredients (APIs) is indispensable for India's growth. However, this view suffers from severe strategic myopia. It treats international trade as an apolitical transaction, completely divorced from the realities of comprehensive national power.

By advocating a return to the pre-2020 status quo, these economic actors choose to selectively forget a dozen years of relentless, unprovoked aggression by the People's Liberation Army (PLA) and the Chinese Communist Party (CCP). The list of Beijing's hostile acts against Indian sovereignty is not a series of isolated border skirmishes; it is a coherent strategy of containment and

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Shashi Tharoor

Fourth-term Member of Parliament (Lok Sabha) for Thiruvananthapuram (Congress party), the Chairman of the Parliamentary Standing Committee on External Affairs and the Sahitya Akademi. Award-winning author of 29 books, including 'Pax India' (2012) and 'The New World Disorder' (2020)

humiliation. From Depsang (2013) and Chumar (2014) to Doklam (2017) and then the fatal clashes in the Galwan Valley (2020), China has systematically attempted to alter the Line of Actual Control (LAC) through salami-slicing tactics, unilaterally violating decades of border peace protocols. Beijing continues to aggressively assert absurd claims over the entire State of Arunachal Pradesh, renaming geographical features in places it does not control (but plans to), and issuing stapled visas to residents of Jammu and Kashmir and Arunachal to weaponise India's internal geography.

And then there is economic coercion. China has routinely used its manufacturing dominance as a political weapon, abruptly withholding critical machinery and industrial inputs, even weaponising its monopoly over rare earths and tunnel-boring machines during bilateral disputes, simply to inconvenience Indian industries and signal its leverage, knowing fully that India has none to exercise in return. Most alarming has been Beijing's overt, coordinated military support for Pakistan during Operation Sindoor (May 2025). By providing Islamabad with real-time tactical satellite data and intelligence, China transformed itself from a mere military supplier into an active, hostile participant in Pakistan's security architecture against India. To ignore this track record in pursuit of cheaper components is not pragmatism; it is strategic blindness.

## The myth of reciprocity

The core flaw in the argument for a quick reset is the naive assumption that if India relaxes its economic guard, China will reciprocate with geopolitical goodwill. The foundational tenet of Chinese foreign policy in Asia is the establishment of a unipolar continent. Beijing does not view New Delhi as a peer, nor does it desire India to become one.

For over a decade, China has weaponised its veto at the United Nations Security Council (UNSC) to shield Pakistan-based terrorist organisations from international sanctions and condemnation. It has blocked India's legitimate aspirations for permanent membership in the UNSC and membership in the Nuclear Suppliers Group (NSG). If India opens the floodgates to Chinese capital and market access without any fundamental resolution of the border dispute or a halt to Beijing's hostile behaviour, it effectively subsidises its own encirclement. Pouring billions of dollars into Chinese coffers as a compliant consumer market merely expands the asymmetric trade deficit (China's annual surplus over India now exceeds \$100 billion). More dangerously, it hands Beijing an economic kill-switch over the Indian economy. In a future crisis, the threat of cutting off critical components could paralyse Indian industry, Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2YRb6rGJOKH6oRd0F>

Realising that Washington is an unreliable partner does not mean India must run into the arms of an actively hostile neighbour

# The youth have risen against authoritarianism

The Prime Minister blinked. The government blinked. Unfortunately, the blinking was over something that was never called for in the yesterdays of politics. A Railway Minister would resign, in those times, following a terrible railway accident.

Not that it was his personal negligence. But he took responsibility as the ultimate authority. Unfortunately, that sense of honour, self-respect, and decency is lost in politics today. The cars with red lights, a house in Lutyens' Delhi, and a false sense of aggrandisement is now the priority.

The resignation of an Education Minister, which should have been immediate – following the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test (Undergraduate) catastrophe – became an issue requiring a huge protest. The reparation of the damage and taking serious and sincere measures to quell the rot in the education system (alas, just one of the many in various departments) required a protest of the magnitude one has seen, to make the government decide to actually perform its duty, function, and responsibility.

## People remain the masters

But one very great takeaway and benefit that has come out of this (for, after all, every negative has



C. Aryama Sundaram

Senior Advocate in the Supreme Court of India

the prospect of resulting in something positive) is that an authoritarian government which had grown to believing, and behaving, like it was a body, a party, above the people, with its threats and possible vindictiveness, to anyone who did not "toe the line", realised that, when you suppress the people, in the end, they are the masters, and the self-important government functionaries are but their servants.

In a way, the NEET incident has been a positive development in the current Indian landscape. At last people have risen against authoritarianism, against fear, against the threat of reprisal, from those who are given power by the very people they now consistently let down. The threat of government reprisal against those who protest or object. The threat of being planted with drugs or false rape charges and of being incarcerated without bail, in the belief that a pliant judicial system would blink, and turn away from injustice, has finally found people, and fortunately the youth of this country who say, "this much and no more".

## Standing united

I am proud of the youth. They have risen as one. With no religious or other artificial divides. They

Without any religious or other artificial divides, the youth of India have shown the courage that their elders lacked

rendering New Delhi incapable of independent strategic decision-making.

Advocates of a reset argue that easing economic tensions could pave the way for a permanent demarcation of the border. In reality, the opposite is true. China respects power and exploits vulnerability. If India surrenders its economic leverage and signals that it cannot sustain a prolonged stand-off, Beijing will conclude that its strategy of multi-domain pressure is working. China will simply bide its time, allowing India to grow comfortably dependent once again. When Beijing eventually decides it is ready to discuss a permanent border settlement, it will dictate terms from a position of absolute dominance. An India structurally dependent on Chinese technology and cowed by the threat of economic disruption will have no choice but to accept a deeply disadvantageous territorial status quo.

Leverage, once surrendered, cannot be easily reclaimed. The restrictions India placed on Chinese apps, investments, and telecom infrastructure post-Galwan were not just emotional reactions; they were crucial diplomatic leverage. Dismantling them for minor economic relief would be an act of unilateral disarmament.

India is undeniably in a complex position. The Trump administration's unpredictable shifts mean that relying entirely on Washington as a security guarantor is unwise, despite the enthusiasm of his emissary to India, Sergio Gorb. The United States will always prioritise its own domestic and global calculations, and New Delhi must remain clear-eyed that it stands alone on the heights of Ladakh. However, realising that Washington is an unreliable partner does not mean India must run into the arms of an actively hostile neighbour. There is an immense strategic space between subordinating India's national interests to the U.S. and conceding an unconditional economic and political surrender to China.

## The path India must tread

The correct path for New Delhi is one of strategic patience and internal fortifying. India must accelerate its supply chain resilience, diversify its trade partnerships across Europe, East Asia, and the Global South, and aggressively build up its domestic manufacturing capabilities – even if it comes with short-term inflationary costs. The last decade has proven that China presents a structural, generational challenge to India's rise. A hasty rethink driven by panic over Washington or the complaints of a short-term-profit-driven business lobby will only ensure that India remains permanently exposed, economically vulnerable, and strategically diminished.

We do not have to "tilt" either way. We must, instead, double the strength to walk straight.

have shown the courage that elders, who had the wherewithal to show, lacked. They have shown us that cowardice, impotence, and a willingness to bow to such authoritarianism as pliant and obedient cattle, to safeguard the positions we have reached without inviting any unrest or destabilisation of our own self-comfort, are unacceptable. Go forth youth. You are not cockroaches. We elders will hopefully find the courage, through your strength, to stop being cockroaches and shed our fears, and not be protective of our own survival.

## Courage unchecked power

The greatest threat to authoritarianism is when it is taken too far and to such sectors that cannot and will not tolerate it anymore. This has been a protest not just against the NEET debacle, but also against the authoritarian rule that prevails. From the heart of a man known to be completely apolitical, and who has judged each issue on the strength of its own right or wrong, unmindful of whether the ruling dispensation or the Opposition is to blame, all I can say is – may this swing against authoritarianism spearheaded by the youth succeed, so that we can all truly say 'Jai Hind'.

## LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

### Youth power triumphs

The Government rarely blinks, having retreated only twice this decade: first over the contentious farm laws, and now in the face of widespread youth anger over systemic failures in national examinations. Standard strategies to diffuse resistance, including the use of force and attempts to discredit the agitation, backfired against a disciplined, decentralised, and digitally savvy youth movement. Crucially, this protest drew participation from social groups within the ruling party's core support base, making prolonged resistance electorally costly. While the removal of the Union Education Minister is aimed at projecting responsiveness, it exposes a rare vulnerability: a muscular administration struggles when confronted

by a self-sustaining, non-partisan public movement with legitimate demands. However, political Opposition parties have little reason to celebrate; the youth's success only highlights the failure of organised politics to serve as an effective platform for public grievances. The renewal of Indian democracy increasingly rests in the hands of a vigilant civil society. The imperative now is structural reform to restore complete integrity and trust in competitive examination bodies.

S. Padmanabhan, Kocchi, Kerala

"Godi Media" and prevented them from covering the protest. This has reinforced the perception among many that sections of the electronic media are biased in favour of the government. As the fourth pillar of democracy, the media must now reflect on its role and strive for greater transparency, balance, and credibility.

Dattaprasad Shirodkar, Mumbai

The 26-day fast by Sonam Wangchuk and the agitations across India are more than sufficient proof that the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test (Undergraduate) should be abolished. The scale of the protests has highlighted the student community's immense frustration with the Union Government. The BJP government's

insistence on maintaining its stand despite widespread unrest across the country suggested that it was more interested in preserving majoritarian politics than in upholding democratic values.

N.G.R. Prasad, Chennai

Gen Z has led the way. The veil of invincibility surrounding the Narendra Modi government has certainly fallen, thanks to the success of the 'Monsoon Revolution' spearheaded by the Cockroach Janta Party. India's conventional mainstream political parties have much to learn from the spirited and no-nonsense conduct of the protests, which were free of extraneous influences. The political landscape will hopefully undergo a positive churn if all stakeholders approach

politics with passion, vision, and unbiased judgment.

Ayyasari Ravendranath, Aramkulam, Kerala

The way Gen Z sought accountability from an authoritarian regime was courageous. But the Minister's resignation is not the real success. The main problems lie within the system, and Gen Z seems to be forgetting this. If one Minister resigns, another will take their place and do whatever the higher authority demands. If we want accountability from politicians, we must recognise the power of the ballot. It is the only way to make politicians fear public opinion. The resignation is not the solution; it is like changing the tyres of a motorbike when the engine itself is at fault.

K. Jashwanth, Hyderabad

While leaders must be held accountable for genuine failures, making resignation the immediate response to every protest can set a dangerous precedent. It may encourage groups to organise demonstrations for every issue, expecting resignations instead of constructive solutions. This could lead to political instability, frequent disruptions, and weaken democratic institutions. Public protests are essential in a democracy, but accountability should follow fair investigations and due process, not public pressure alone. Governments must address grievances responsibly while ensuring that governance remains stable and effective.

Navya Saraf, Hyderabad

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# Indian Monsoon: a democratic tipping point

India stands at an important moment in its democratic journey. Large student demonstrations which were demanding fairness in examinations and Sonam Wangchuk's prolonged fast and hospitalisation along with the start of the Monsoon session of Parliament have together captured the nation's attention. These events viewed together tell a larger story. They signal a growing desire and demand among citizens to be heard, to participate, and shape India's democratic future.

This moment can be described as the Indian Monsoon.

Just as the annual monsoon follows months of intense heat, societies too experience seasons when accumulated aspirations, frustrations, and exclusion seek peaceful democratic expression. Such moments should not be feared. They should be welcomed as opportunities for reflection, dialogue, reform and redesign.

## On imagining a future

India has much to celebrate. The country has expanded digital public infrastructure, modernised transportation, strengthened financial inclusion, and demonstrated achievements in science, technology, and space. These accomplishments have brought recognition for India.

At the same time, many young Indians worry about the credibility of competitive examinations, access to quality education, and the availability of meaningful employment. Farmers continue to face economic uncertainty and income inequality remains a major concern. Public discourse has become increasingly polarised, with many citizens questioning institutional autonomy, the role of the media, the undermining of civil society, and the quality of democratic debate. These concerns should not be viewed through a partisan lens. They should be understood as democratic signals.

The strength of a democracy is measured not by the absence of



Sam Pitroda

Telecom inventor, entrepreneur, development thinker, and policy maker

criticism but by its willingness to listen and reform.

India's greatest asset has always been its extraordinary diversity – of languages, religions, castes, cultures, traditions, trade, ideas, and aspirations. The Indian Constitution transformed that diversity into the foundation of national unity. It affirmed that justice, liberty, equality, and fraternity are not just abstract ideals but practical principles for governing a vibrant society.

As India moves toward the centenary of its Independence in 2047, there is an opportunity to renew that constitutional promise. The real question is: what kind of India do we want to build for the next generation? Do we aspire merely to become a larger economy, or do we seek to become a more inclusive, more equitable, more scientific, more innovative, more peaceful and compassionate society?

This Monsoon moment calls for a new national agenda.

The government must restore complete confidence in our education and examination systems. It must create millions of meaningful jobs by encouraging decentralisation, district-level development, entrepreneurship, innovation, and local manufacturing. It must also strengthen public healthcare, improve nutrition, low-cost housing, safety, security, schools, vocational training, invest in scientific research, reduce bureaucracy, and expand technology and opportunities for every young Indian, regardless of their background.

Above all, India must prepare for the age of Artificial Intelligence (AI). AI is not simply another technological revolution. It will reshape and redefine work, education, healthcare, agriculture, manufacturing, communities, villages, cities, governance and employment.

India possesses the raw young talent, entrepreneurial spirit, and digital foundation to become a global leader in AI for public good.

Its challenge is to ensure that technology serves every citizen sustainably. No algorithm can replace trust and no AI system can replace human wisdom.

Our future therefore depends upon combining technological excellence with constitutional values, scientific temper, ethical leadership, and respect for humanity.

## The idea of India

Perhaps, the greatest challenge before India today is not economic or technological. It is philosophical – the idea of India rooted in our Constitution. That ideology needs to be the core of our development, and the prerequisite for a path to prosperity. For far too long has the world measured success primarily through the pursuit of power and profit. The time has come to rebalance our priorities: to place people and the planet at the centre of development. If we empower every young person, reduce inequality, strengthen democratic institutions, focus on humanity and not religion, and use technology to expand opportunity rather than privilege, India can offer the world a new developmental model – one that combines economic progress with human dignity.

The Indian Monsoon is therefore not a political movement. It is a democratic season of renewal. It reminds us that governments derive strength by listening to their citizens, and that India's greatest achievements have always come when we have chosen dialogue over division.

History will judge us by whether we had the wisdom to listen, the courage to reform, and the imagination to build an India worthy of its civilisational promise and its democratic project. If we seize this moment with humility, confidence and vision, the Indian Monsoon will not merely mark another season of public debate. It will mark the beginning of India's next democratic renaissance.

# A gamble on the Cauvery issue

CM Vijay aims to hold direct talks with Karnataka for water-sharing

## STATE OF PLAY

T. Ramakrishnan

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister and Tamilaga Vetti Kazhagam (TVK) president C. Joseph Vijay's decision to initiate talks with his Karnataka counterpart D. K. Shivakumar on the Cauvery issue marks a departure from the State's traditional policy over the Cauvery dispute.

The purpose of Mr. Vijay's visit to Bengaluru is to impress on the upper riparian State the imperative for it to release the share of water due to Tamil Nadu, as stipulated in the final award of the Cauvery Water Disputes Tribunal (CWDT) in 2007 which was amended by the Supreme Court 11 years later. Between June 1 and July 23, the State should have realised around 32 thousand million cubic feet (tmc ft) of water but what it got was about 3.5 tmc ft. Keeping in mind the deficient rainfall from the southwest monsoon over the river's catchment and its own formula of proportionate reduction, Tamil Nadu feels that it should have received at least three tmc ft more.

## A new strategy

Mr. Vijay's outreach has evoked disapproval from many political parties, farmers' leaders, and experts alike, as direct negotiations, in their assessment, would amount to bypassing the established implementation mechanism – the Cauvery Water Management Authority (CWMA) and the Cauvery Water Regulation Committee – as per the final award and the Court's judgment. Besides, Tamil Nadu has been, since the CWDT's establishment in June 1990, a strong votary of adjudication to resolve the vexatious pro-



blem of sharing river water in contrast to its neighbour's preference for talks. On several occasions, it had outrightly spurned offers for talks made by various leaders of Karnataka. In the last 35-odd years, there were occasions when the State took part in bilateral and multilateral discussions but this was part of the Supreme Court's intervention.

Even though the CWDT's formation itself was an outcome of the failure of 26 rounds of negotiations held over 22 years, Mr. Vijay seems to be receptive to the idea of chalking out a path that his predecessors did not favour. What should be helpful to him is that in Karnataka, the ruling party is the Congress, a junior partner in his coalition government. The Congress' former president, Rahul Gandhi, was a prominent attendee at Mr. Vijay's swearing in event in May. Further, Mr. Shivakumar himself was among the early leaders from other States to greet Mr. Vijay on becoming the Chief Minister. It is possible that the TVK chief has thought of capitalising on his equations with Mr. Shivakumar and the Congress party to break new ground in the Cauvery problem.

At the same time, Mr. Vijay should know, by now, that personal relationships and striking a deal on contentious and long-standing disputes are two distinct matters. After all, many of his predecessors,

especially M. Karunanidhi and M.G. Ramachandran (MGR), had equally good, if not better, ties with their Karnataka peers such as Veerendra Patil, D. Devaraj Urs, R. Gundu Rao, Ramakrishna Hegde, and J.H. Patel. Rao had even invited MGR, according to diplomat-political writer R. Kannan's biography on the latter, to join the Congress after his exit from the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam in 1972.

Nine years later, MGR, as Chief Minister, visited Bengaluru in October 1981 originally for a day's talks with Rao but had to extend his stay by one more day. Even then, no breakthrough was achieved.

It is well known that when it came to the Cauvery, the upper riparian State's Chief Ministers would give substantively nothing to the other side.

## Clubbing of issues

What is also troubling several parties and groups in Tamil Nadu over the proposed talks is the possibility of the Karnataka government using this occasion to raise the Mekedatu dam project, which the lower riparian State has been opposing on the ground that it will jeopardise its irrigation requirements. There is substance in their apprehension but Tamil Nadu has to convey to Karnataka that it can have talks separately, and as when necessary, as it has sought the formation of an exclusive tribunal to handle the subject. For the time being, its focus is on obtaining immediate relief from Karnataka in terms of water release.

If the two States go beyond and agree on a distress water-sharing formula which can be presented to the CWMA for ratification, it will be a real feather in Mr. Vijay's cap.

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# Need to shift focus to rising student suicides, cost of education

As the protests led by the CJP end, larger systemic issues associated with high-stakes entrance examinations such as NEET need to be addressed

## DATA POINT

Sambavi Parthasarathy

The sustained protests led by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) demanding accountability over paper leaks in the National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (NEET) came to an end on Saturday with the government accepting many of their demands, including the resignation of Union Minister of Education Dharmendra Pradhan, compensation for the families of the deceased who ended their lives over the NEET paper leaks, and the withdrawal of criminal cases against protesters.

Thousands of protesters who gathered across many places in the country despite crackdown by the government, including brutal police action in Delhi on July 20, have termed Mr. Pradhan's resignation a 'historic win'. While their demands have successfully pinned accountability for a leaked question paper, larger questions around high-stakes entrance exams – the NEET in particular – such as the proliferation of coaching centres, increased expenditure for families, and high levels of stress experienced by students, remain unaddressed.

Over 20 lakh students appeared for NEET in the first week of May. Reports indicate that more than a dozen students died by suicide after the exam was cancelled and rescheduled due to widespread allegations of question papers getting leaked. These suicides cannot be seen in isolation. The number of student suicides increased by about 80% from 8,068 in 2014 to 14,488 in 2024, the latest year for which the Accidental Deaths and Suicides in India (ADSI) report by the National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB) has been published.

Over 1.23 lakh students ended their lives between 2014 and 2024 in the country (Chart 1).

The Ministry of Education stated in Parliament that suicides

among students are driven by various causes such as academic stress, family problems, mental health issues, financial distress and interpersonal conflicts. The ADSI reports capture 'failure in examination' as a distinct category of reason for suicides. Suicides for which 'failure in examination' was the primary reason accounted for 21%, or more than one-fifth, of the total number of student suicides between 2014 and 2024. Over 2,000 students died every year due to failure in examinations, with 2021 being the only exception. Cumulatively, over 25,000 students died by suicide due to failure in exams between 2014 and 2024, of which 55% were under 18 years and another 42% between 18 and 30 years of age (Chart 2).

Though student suicides cannot be seen in the context of NEET alone, this highly competitive medical entrance exam has come to symbolise these systemic issues. The exam has repeatedly come under focus for issues such as paper leaks, inhumane levels of checking of students while entering exam halls, and concerns over unusually high-scoring patterns from select centres. Over 15 lakh students have registered for the NEET examination every year since 2015. However, those who made it to the pool of qualified candidates is less than 57% (Chart 3).

Moreover, the need to join private coaching and the reality that many have to repeat the exam after the exam was cancelled and rescheduled due to widespread allegations of question papers getting leaked. These suicides cannot be seen in isolation. The number of student suicides increased by about 80% from 8,068 in 2014 to 14,488 in 2024, the latest year for which the Accidental Deaths and Suicides in India (ADSI) report by the National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB) has been published.

Over 1.23 lakh students ended their lives between 2014 and 2024 in the country (Chart 1). The Ministry of Education stated in Parliament that suicides



Chart 1: Number of students who died by suicide between 2014 and 2024

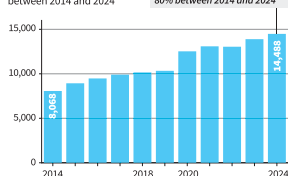


Chart 2: Number of students who registered for NEET and number of students who qualified

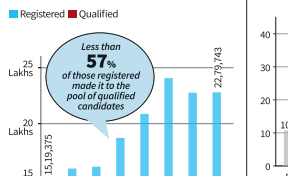
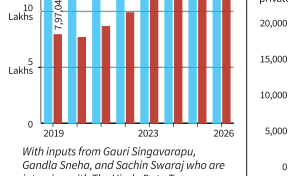


Chart 3: Share of students (in %) who were taking/had taken private coaching during an academic year as per CMS:E 2025 at different levels of enrolment



With inputs from Gauri Singwarapu, Gandia Sneh, and Sachin Swargi who are intern with The Hindu Data Team

## Under pressure

The data for the charts were sourced from the National Testing Agency's press releases, the Accidental Deaths and Suicides in India (ADSI) reports, and Comprehensive Modular survey: Education 2025 (CMS:E 2025)

Carrying the flame: Supporters lighting candles to pay homage to the students who died by suicide after the NEET paper leak during the third day of protests by the Cockroach Janta Party, at Jantar Mantar in New Delhi on June 22. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA / THE HINDU

Chart 4a: Average expenditure (₹) per student on school education and private coaching by level of enrolment

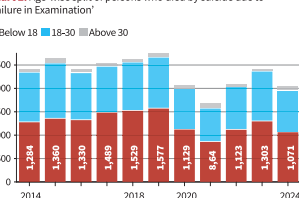
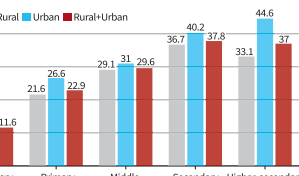


Chart 4b: Average expenditure (₹) per student on school education and private coaching by level of enrolment



## FROM THE ARCHIVES

### The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO JULY 27, 1976

## 'Roman letter' on Mars rock

Pasadena (California), July 26: Commands relayed to Mars from U.S. scientists on earth apparently straightened out a hitch in Viking's soil-sampling arm yesterday.

But another key experiment the seismology probe, appeared to be beyond the reach of earth-bound repairmen.

Pictures from the Viking lander on Sunday showed a tiny knobby lying on the Martian dust. That meant the pin believed to have caused the jamming of the soil sampler's arm, had fallen away as planned.

Late last week after the problem cropped up scientists discovered through a model of the lander at the Jet Propulsion Laboratory (JPL) that by extending the arm a bit the problem pin would drop free. That was what happened yesterday on Mars, scientists said.

"Everybody is very happy about it and we are ready to move right along," said the Viking Project Manager, Mr. James Martin. "We are moving right on ahead."

New closeup pictures of the Chryse plain on Mars revealed what appeared to be a rock bearing the Roman letters "B" and "C" and the Arabic numeral "2". Scientists said the characters were optical illusions caused by shadowing.

"People are great at imagining things," said Dr. Carl Sagan. Dr. Bruce Murray, Director of the Jet Propulsion laboratory agreed.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO JULY 27, 1926

## Growing chaos in China

An "Englishman" cable from London dated July 25, states:—

Mr. Percival London, cabling to the "Daily Telegraph" from Peking, declares that China is on the verge of bankruptcy.

He says it is difficult to describe the intense feeling of pessimism reigning among all classes. China is in a state of helpless chaos and local tyranny is blasting any hope of extricating any part of the country from the welter of militarism and corruption. The situation can only be retrieved if the slackness of Europe is abandoned and a genuine attempt made by the Powers to act unitedly.

The steady and impartial administration of the Customs under Sir Francis Aglen, enabling the collection of revenues, is the one bright spot in a gloomy pastures.

# Text & Context

THE HINDU

## NEWS IN NUMBERS

### Number of Delhi schools found with safety deficiencies

**774** Private schools accounted for the highest number of cases. According to a statement from Lok Nivas, 1,677 schools were inspected between July 13 and 24. Safety deficiencies were found in 270 government schools, 463 private schools and 41 government-aided schools. PTI

### People still affected by the Assam flood situation

**6.5** in lakh. The flood situation in Assam improved on Sunday as water levels were receding in most of the affected areas with those places not receiving overnight rainfall, even as over 6.5 lakh people remained hit in six districts and 66 people lost their lives in this year's deluge. PTI

### People evacuated in South China due to Typhoon Noul landfall

**3.4** in lakh. Typhoon Noul made landfall early Sunday and was bringing winds and heavy rain to southern China, including Hong Kong. China's weather centre said Noul made landfall along the coast of Huidong county of the city of Huizhou in the southern Guangdong province. PTI

### Number of people evacuated from the biggest forest fire

**2.2** in lakh. French authorities said that more than 2,20,000 people have been evacuated from the forest fire raging in the southwest of the country that has also forced the closure of highways and rail lines. More than 50,000 people have also been ordered to leave villages around Bordeaux. AFP

### Maharashtra: share of SIR enumeration forms distributed

**87.8** Maharashtra has distributed 87.79% of enumeration forms and digitised 60.44% of them under the ongoing SIR of electoral rolls, officials said. The enumeration phase is being carried out from June 30 to August 8. PTI

COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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# Why is China's AI push gaining ground?

How have Chinese firms caught up with leading U.S. AI models despite chip restrictions? What advantages do Chinese open-source AI models offer over captive models? How has Beijing supported the growth? What challenges could China face in the future?

## EXPLAINER

Aroon Deep

### The story so far:

A matter of weeks after Anthropic's Fable AI model was launched to great acclaim, Chinese firm Moonshot AI released Kimi K3, a model that has measured up to the Claude model in most parameters. The notable factor here is that K3, and a clutch of other models made in China, are open-weight and/or open-source, meaning that any company (or well-resourced individual) can run them locally.

### How is China positioning itself in AI?

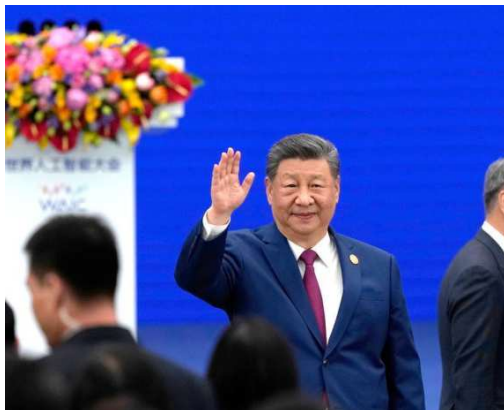
At the Shanghai World AI Conference on July 17, Chinese president Xi Jinping said that with AI, countries "should adhere to the principle of openness and win-win and boost innovation-driven development". At least as far as the currently available open models are concerned, Chinese firms are walking that talk.

China faces crucial restrictions on graphics processing units (GPUs) that are required for training AI models and running queries (inference) on them. However, China has bridged this gap with abundant electricity access and a larger quantity of less advanced chips. The result is models like Kimi K3, which is a 2.8 trillion parameter model.

### How have they built a competitive ecosystem?

Not all open-source models are designed for those many parameters; Alibaba, the retail and e-commerce giant that is now growing significant in-house AI capabilities, has put out several lightweight models that have impressed AI enthusiasts who prefer to run inference on their own hardware.

China has supported AI research labs as well as encouraged existing large firms like Tencent and Baidu to work on AI,



**Gearing up:** Chinese president Xi Jinping: China's results are indicative of long-term planning that it had set in motion for the AI ecosystem. AP

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://t.me/+8B98m5PQCF84MnQ9> which has resulted in a multiplicity of models that have been downloaded millions of times from platforms like HuggingFace, with developers enthusiastically adopting these models for narrow, tailored use-cases.

One of the most well-known entrants that challenged U.S. dominance is the startup DeepSeek, whose models are available online as well as on an open-source basis. The Chinese government has also acted to protect these firms from being co-opted into the U.S.-led AI ecosystem, such as by restricting travel for key personnel and blocking Facebook parent Meta's acquisition of the firm Manus.

### What does this mean for the global race?

The difference between open-source and captive models – Anthropic and OpenAI's

models, as well as most of Google's, land in the latter category – is that source code is not freely shared with the broader AI developer ecosystem, giving firms a theoretical edge. But another key difference that could counteract that advantage is that open-source models can be run by third-party providers who compete with others like them to provide greater cost predictability.

This is so far a theoretical advantage, since the U.S.'s frontier firms are greatly subsidising their models; Anthropic is this month giving out \$100 in credits to paying users to use their Fable model. But once that exuberance dies down, the focus may very well shift to infrastructure providers, who may find open-source models an attractive offering.

This is, of course, assuming that open-source models continue to be provided freely by Chinese firms in the

coming months and years. Alibaba has already started working on captive AI models that run on its own infrastructure and are not open-source.

Since open-source models are expensive to produce, it may not be a given that they will be trained at the same clip, as the companies most capable of making them may change business models.

Chinese firms have caught up in capability, but there remains a trust deficit, especially in India, on using their models. Open-sourcing models means that local firms running on inference aggregators like Neysa and even the IT Ministry's Computer Emergency Response Team (CERT-in) make use of these models, since no question of data leakage emerges.

The bet may very well be that once the open-source honeymoon ends, and the world has seen how good Chinese models are compared to the most advanced Western counterparts, captive models may get a second consideration, even allowing for the geopolitical baggage that comes with embracing Chinese technology.

Things may not necessarily move in that direction, as the existing models and their accompanying literature are being studied by researchers and labs around the world.

The geopolitical baggage has likely been a major reason why India, despite hosting the AI Impact Summit in February, skipped out on the Shanghai conference. The government is trying to encourage domestic champions and hold off Chinese capital in Indian AI by promoting firms like Sarvam AI in spite of scarce resources. However, as noted above, open-source models have not been discouraged.

China's results are indicative of long-term planning that its government had set in motion for the AI ecosystem.

The next major focus area, Mr. Jinping indicated in his speech, was AI "moving from the digital world into the physical world."

## THE GIST

China's open-source AI push has rapidly narrowed the capability gap with U.S. frontier models, backed by State support, efficient use of computing resources, and a growing ecosystem of developers and firms.

While open models could reshape the global AI market through lower-cost deployment, questions over long-term business models, geopolitical trust, and India's push for domestic AI champions will influence their adoption.

# Why has India moved to take down BitChat repositories?

What is BitChat? Can communication tools be blocked for their potential misuse?

Rizmi Lia M.

### The story so far:

The Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C), under the Ministry of Home Affairs, directed GitHub on July 23 to remove repositories hosting BitChat, the Bluetooth mesh messaging application developed by X co-founder Jack Dorsey, stating that the app could be exploited to coordinate unlawful assemblies and circumvent lawful restrictions imposed by competent authorities during situations involving public order. The order comes at a time when repeated internet shutdowns near protest sites have led protesters to increasingly rely on Bluetooth-enabled messaging platforms such as BitChat for communication.

### What is BitChat?

BitChat is a decentralised peer-to-peer messaging application that operates over Bluetooth mesh networks. It requires no

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://t.me/+8B98m5PQCF84MnQ9> internet connection, no servers and no phone numbers.

Traditional messaging apps depend on centralised infrastructure that can be monitored, censored or disabled. BitChat creates ad hoc communication networks using only devices in physical proximity, with each device acting as both a client and a server, automatically discovering peers and relaying messages across multiple hops to extend the network's reach.

According to the platform, this approach provides censorship resistance, surveillance resistance and infrastructure independence. The network remains functional during internet outages, natural disasters, protests, or in regions with limited connectivity.

### What does the order say?

The order directs GitHub to disable access to three repositories, including the Android application and its release files, within three hours.

It also warns that failure to comply

could invite criminal prosecution.

According to the order, the application enables anonymous communication without mandatory user registration, phone number verification or centralised logging of communications. It states that the application's technical architecture significantly impedes lawful interception, attribution and investigation by law enforcement agencies.

It further states that since communications occur directly between nearby devices through a decentralised mesh network, the platform can be misused to evade lawful surveillance, facilitate anonymous coordination and circumvent lawful restrictions imposed by competent authorities during situations involving public order, riots, terrorism, organised crime or internet shutdowns.

The order also states that "such decentralised communication platforms are capable of being exploited for coordinating unlawful assemblies, violent protests, dissemination of misinformation, radicalisation, criminal

conspiracies, and other activities prejudicial to the sovereignty and integrity of India, defence of India, security of the State, public order, and for facilitating the commission of cognizable offences."

### What does the law say?

The order, Notice No. II07260101H432, was issued at 11.16 p.m. on July 23 under Section 79(3)(b) of the Information Technology Act, 2000, read with Rule 30(d) of the Information Technology (Intermediary Guidelines and Digital Media Ethics Code) Rules, 2021.

Section 79(3)(b) provides that an intermediary may lose its safe harbour protection if, upon receiving actual knowledge or being notified by the appropriate government or its agency that any information, data or communication link residing in or connected to a computer resource controlled by the intermediary is being used to commit an unlawful act, it fails to expeditiously remove or disable access to that material without vitiating the evidence in any manner.

However, Section 79 itself does not confer a blocking power. Blocking directions are ordinarily issued under Section 69A of the IT Act and the Blocking Rules, 2009, which require a hearing and reasons recorded in writing, subject to review.

It empowers the Union government to direct the blocking of public access to information on grounds such as national

security, public order and the prevention of incitement to the commission of cognisable offences. Such orders are required to follow the procedure prescribed under the law.

### Why is the order being criticised?

The Internet Freedom Foundation (IFF) criticised the order, arguing that it relies on the application's potential for misuse rather than identifying any unlawful content hosted in the repositories. "Anticipated misuse of a communications tool is not a lawful basis to prohibit the tool," the organisation said.

The order directs GitHub to "remove and disable access to the concerned URLs within three hours of the issue of this communication without vitiating evidence in any manner."

According to IFF, the notice, issued close to midnight, fails the proportionality standard laid down by the Supreme Court in *Anuradha Bhasin v. Union of India* (2020).

In *Anuradha Bhasin*, the Supreme Court held that "the degree of restriction and the scope of the same, both territorially and temporally, must stand in relation to what is actually necessary to combat an emergent situation." The court observed that the principle of proportionality requires restrictions to be tailored to the territorial extent of the restriction, the stage of the emergency, the nature of the urgency, the duration of the restrictive measure and the nature of the restriction.



CACHE



GETTY IMAGES

# Why India must modernise the way govt. publishes laws and regulations

India's legal publishing system remains fragmented and dependent on PDFs, making it difficult for citizens, lawyers and even courts to access, track laws and amendments in force; adopting open legal publishing standards would make laws more accessible and strengthen democratic participation

Sushant Sinha

When the Transvaal government enacted the notorious "Black Act" against Indians in 1906, Mahatma Gandhi's first act was not to protest but to translate the ordinance and publish it in full in his newspaper, *Indian Opinion*, so that ordinary Indians could read for themselves exactly what was being done to them. Gandhi understood that a community cannot defend its rights against a law it cannot read.

Today a variety of laws govern us: Acts and their amendments, rules, regulations, BIS standards, road standards, circulars, municipal bylaws, and more. Yet there is no single place to find out what the law actually is – it lies scattered across multiple websites. The rule of law requires that Bills presented before Parliament or a State Assembly be made known to the people in advance, that citizens are aware of the laws and amendments in force, and that the judiciary knows the state of the law it adjudicates. In reality, Bills are often not placed in the public domain before they are introduced. Citizens struggle to find the law in force, and even when they locate a copy, determining what the law was on a given date is a battle of its own.

## Lost in the gazettes

As a legal publisher, we were incorporating the changes made by the Code of Criminal Procedure

**Govt. uses gazettes as its primary means of publishing laws and bringing them into force. These gazettes are published as PDFs, a format created in the early 1990s**

(Amendment) Act, 2005 into the principal Act. The amendment left it to the government to decide when its various sections would come into force, so we began searching the gazettes for the notifications bringing them into effect. To our surprise, we could find no gazette notifying Sections 16, 25, 28(a), 28(b), 38, 42(a), 42(b), 42(f)(ii) and (iv), and 44(a). We filed an RTI application with the Ministry of Home Affairs, which confirmed that these sections have never been notified. In other words, more than two decades later, they are still not valid law.

The government uses gazettes as its primary means of publishing laws and bringing them into force. These gazettes are published as PDFs, a format created in the early 1990s to ensure that a digital document looks identical on every device by embedding fonts and images. While this makes PDFs easy to share and print, it also makes it very hard to extract the structure and meaning of a legal document. A law is inherently hierarchical – chapters, parts, sections, subsections – but a PDF exposes none of that hierarchy. Many gazettes published in regional languages contain proprietary fonts, which look fine on a PDF viewer

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://t.me/+8B98m5PQCF84MmQ9> but cannot be searched in regional language or read on any websites.

## Learning from global standards

Governments in several countries have moved to publishing laws in markup languages that properly capture their structure, semantics and the local languages. Many African countries have adopted the Akoma Ntoso standard, a markup language specifically designed for legal documents. They use an open-source legal publishing platform called Indigo, which allows users to add or edit laws. You can apply amendments to an Act and see precisely what changed across successive amendments – and what the law was at any given point in time. Subordinate rules and regulations can also be tagged to their principal Act and amended in the same way.

The United States publishes its laws in a variant of Akoma Ntoso called USLM (United States Legislative Markup). Every law and amendment is published in USLM, while the PDF and HTML versions are generated automatically from it using a stylesheet. All past issues of the Federal Register have also been converted and are available for bulk download. As a result, not only commercial legal vendors but also nonprofits, think tanks and others can use them to help citizens better engage with their democracy.

The United Kingdom publishes its legislation at [legislation.gov.uk](http://legislation.gov.uk), run by The National Archives. The base format for the content is the Crown Legislation

Markup Language (CLML), another modified version of Akoma Ntoso. The National Archives has stated that it aims to move towards Akoma Ntoso because it is emerging as the international standard, is less complex, and is supported by a wider pool of experts and suppliers.

## Making the law accessible

While the rest of the world has moved away from PDF publishing, we remain dependent on a standard that was built more than three decades back. Until we upgrade the government's legal publishing software stack, access to the law will remain unnecessarily difficult for citizens, lawyers, judges and other stakeholders in a democracy.

The Internet itself was built on open standards. People came together to standardise communication protocols, which every stakeholder then adopted. Dr. B.R. Ambedkar often reminded us that a democracy needs more than a government "for the people"; it needs a government "by the people." Laws are the raw material of our democracy, and leaving their publication to a handful of contractors will only deepen the obscurity. If instead the government consults its citizens and standardises legal publishing, it could transform how the state communicates with the people and make them an active part of democracy. (Sushant Sinha did his PhD in Computer Science from University of Michigan and is the founder of legal search engine, Indian Kanoon)



## KNOW YOUR ENGLISH

# She was dialled in during the presentation

Complaining all the time doesn't become you

S. Upendran

"Nice shirt! Haven't seen it before. New?"  
"Bought it during last week's sale. What do you think? Is it..."  
"It becomes you."  
"The shirt becomes me?"  
"When you tell someone that the 'shirt becomes you', what you're suggesting is that the shirt suits him."  
"In other words, you're complimenting the person."  
"Exactly! It's usually used to suggest that something looks good on the individual. I think blue becomes you."  
"Meaning the colour suits me. According to my mother, white T-shirts become me."  
"That's a good example! The expression can also be used to talk about someone's behaviour. For example, making fun of people doesn't become you because..."

"It's probably another way of saying, you shouldn't be making fun of others because when you do, it makes you less attractive."

"Very good! I think you should stop complaining. It just doesn't become you."  
"Displaying confidence becomes you."

"While we're on the subject of confidence, did your boss manage to convince the client?"

"The client was impressed with the presentation she made. The team said that they'd get back to us by the end of the week."

"I was surprised your boss made the presentation."

"The CEO asked her to do it. She did a great job. She was dialled in."  
"What do you mean by 'dialled in'?"

"The expression is frequently used in informal contexts. When you say that someone is dialled in on a task, what you mean is that he is very focussed."

"The person will do a good job."  
"Or at least he'll attempt to. Whenever Sinister plays Djokovic, he's dialled in."

"At this year's Wimbledon, he certainly was. There are many players who find it difficult to dial in if the opponent is weak."

"The superstar turned down the role because he just couldn't dial into the character he'd been asked to play."

"Meaning that he just couldn't get a feel for the character?"

"I guess you could say that."  
"Tell me, where does the expression 'dial in' come from?"

"The expression has nothing to do with the telephone. It has more to do with the old radio. In the past, you had to be careful when you tuned in."

"That's right! If you hadn't dialled in properly, you got a lot of static."

"So, you had to keep turning the knob till you found your specific setting."

"The other day Sujatha was telling me that I had a face for radio. What did she mean by that?"

"How important is your face when you're speaking into a microphone?"  
"Not important."

"Exactly! When you say someone has a face for radio, what you're suggesting is that the individual is unattractive."

"I see."  
"My friend has a great body. But unfortunately, he has a face for radio."

"You can't have everything in life, I guess."  
[upendrankye@gmail.com](mailto:upendrankye@gmail.com)

## THE DAILY QUIZ

How well do you know Vincent van Gogh, one of history's most celebrated and influential artists?

Prathmesh Kher

### QUESTION 1

Vincent van Gogh's painting *The Starry Night* depicts the view from the window of which institution where he was staying?

### QUESTION 2

Which fellow artist did Van Gogh invite to live and work with him in the "Yellow House" at Arles?

### QUESTION 3

Van Gogh was deeply influenced by Japanese woodblock prints, a style collectively known by what Japanese term?

### QUESTION 4

What was Van Gogh's profession before he decided to become an artist?

### QUESTION 5

Van Gogh died in July 1890 in which French village?



### Visual Question:

This is generally believed to be the only painting Vincent van Gogh sold during his lifetime. Identify it. VINCENT VAN GOGH/PUBLIC DOMAIN

### Questions and Answers to the previous day's daily quiz: 1.

This controversial law offering a path to Indian citizenship to six religious minority communities from neighbouring countries led to nationwide protests in 2019 and 2020. Name the law. **Ans: Citizenship (Amendment) Act**

2. In 2015, students of this education centre went on strike protesting the government's appointment of a television actor-turned-politician as chairperson. What is the name of the education centre and the name of the appointee? **Ans: Film and Television Institute of India, Gajendra Chauhan**

3. A global pop star and a prominent climate activist posted on X in support of protests that

captured global headlines for days in India in 2021. Their posts sparked a reaction from the Indian government. Name them. **Ans: Rihanna, Greta Thunberg**

4. The 2016 death by suicide of this student drew attention to the fight against institutional caste discrimination. **Ans: Rohith Vemula**

5. What is the name of the judicial committee formed to recommend amendments to India's criminal laws in the incident's aftermath? **Ans: Justice Verma Committee**

Visual: Name the man and woman in the photo. **Ans: Anna Hazare and Kiran Bedi**

**Early Birds:** Tamal Biswas | Mohan Lal Patel | Parimal Das | Siddhartha Viswanathan | Sumana Dutta

Please send in your answers to [dailyquiz@thehindu.co.in](mailto:dailyquiz@thehindu.co.in)

## Word of the day

### Aplomb:

complete poise, assurance, and self-confidence, especially in a difficult or challenging situation

**Synonyms:** calmness, composure, coolness

**Usage:** She answered the difficult questions with aplomb.

**Pronunciation:** [newstv.live/aplomb](https://www.nestlelive.com/aplomb)

**International Phonetic Alphabet:** /ˈaplɒm/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to [letters@thehindu.co.in](mailto:letters@thehindu.co.in) with the subject 'Text & Context'

## From Page One

## Nilekani to lead task force on exam reforms

Mr. Nilekani has worked with the Union government in the past to set up the Aadhaar ecosystem and Unified Payments Interface (UPI). He is also the chairperson of the governing body of the economic policy research think tank, the National Council of Applied Economic Research (NCAER), and a co-founder of Infosys.

## Joshi takes charge

After assuming charge of the Education Ministry, Mr. Joshi told the media, "The Prime Minister has entrusted me with this responsibility with full confidence. I was in Karnataka yesterday. I reached here last night and came this morning to take charge. I have assumed charge."

"I am reviewing all the details here and the decisions that need to be taken. I have been gathering information and trying to understand the functioning of the Ministry. We had continuous meetings today. This is a new subject for me. I have taken charge today and held detailed discussions with the senior officers. It is a very big department, so I will speak to you in detail after I have understood it completely," Mr. Joshi stated.

Union Minister of State for Education Jayant Chaudhary attended the meeting. Officials said Mr. Joshi reviewed key schemes, including Samagra Shiksha, PM-SHRI Schools and PM POSHAN, and discussed school infrastructure.

Higher Education Department Secretary, School Education and Literacy Department Secretary, and other senior officials of the Ministry were present.

## Centre warns Indians about jobs in Black Sea

Indian seafarers were urged to follow all the advisories issued by the Directorate General of Maritime Administration, including the one on July 23.

## Search and rescue under way

The latest advisory came a day after the MV *AGN Ragnar* was struck at the port of Odesa. "Four Indian nationals were on board the vessel. As per the latest information, two have been confirmed safe, and information is awaited regarding the other two nationals. Search and rescue operations are under way. The Embassy is in constant touch with the authorities concerned," the Indian Embassy in Kyiv said, without specifying who had fired the projectile that hit the ship.

Earlier on July 19, the *MV Golden Leo*, a Guinea Bissau-flagged ship, was also hit by projectiles that led to the deaths of 10 seafarers, of whom four were Indian citizens. This incident had prompted the MEA to summon the chargé d'affaires of the Russian Embassy in India.

## Iran says it is halting 'retaliatory strikes'

Soon after the war started, Iran said it had laid mines along the central part of the Strait traditionally used for merchant ship navigation and designated a "safe" route along its coast, an effective way to extend its control over the Strait.

Iran said on Sunday that it had made progress in talks with neighbouring Oman, which holds the opposite coast of the Strait, on "common principles and operational mechanisms" for ships in the Strait. While the two nations had come up with a proposal in June to jointly administer the Strait and monetise it, the U.S. had refused to accept any Iranian control.



Rajnath Singh pays tribute to fallen soldiers of the 1999 Kargil War on the 27th Kargil Vijay Diwas, at Drass, in Ladakh on Sunday. **IRAN NISSAR**

## Dialogue with Pak. will only be on PoK: Rajnath

Mr. Singh said Pakistan's military works in tandem with terrorist organisations.

He contrasted the trajectories of the two neighbours, saying India is focused on innovation, semiconductors, space technology and digital payments, while Pakistan continues to promote terrorism, infiltration, radicalisation and proxy warfare.

Mr. Singh said the Indian government has given the armed forces a free hand to respond decisively to threats and expressed confidence that no adversary would dare cast a hostile eye on India while its soldiers guard the borders.

Highlighting progress in defence indigenisation, Mr. Singh said India now manufactures nearly 65% of its defence equipment domestically, compared to importing 65-70% when the present government assumed office.

## Tejashwi Yadav demands release of brother, others

Bihar's Leader of Opposition warns of massive agitation if protesters are not released in 24 hours; seeks govt. action against police personnel who 'opened fire at students' at Siwan and Jehanabad

**Amrit Bhatnari**  
PATNA

Lashing out at the State police for the arrest of hundreds of agitators during the Bihar Bandh, Leader of the Opposition Tejashwi Yadav on Sunday demanded the immediate release of students, Opposition MLAs, and other protesters, including his elder brother Tej Pratap Yadav. If they are not released within 24 hours, he warned the State government that they would hit the streets once again.

The Bihar Bandh was called by the All India Students' Association (AISA) on Saturday. It turned violent in places and resulted in clashes with the police, who opened fire in Siwan, while hundreds were arrested.

Among those arrested was Mr. Tej Pratap, who is no longer a member of the Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) and has formed his own political outfit. He was arrested by the Patna Police on charges of obstructing government officials from discharging their duties and sent to judicial custody for 14 days in Beur Jail.

"The Centre decided yesterday to withdraw all the cases against the protesting students and youth (in Delhi). The [Bihar] government should follow suit," Mr. Tejashwi told presspersons at Patna airport, where he was accompanied by his mother and former Chief Minister Rabri Devi.

"Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary must release everyone, including my brother, within 24 hours or be ready to face a massive agitation, and students and youth will once again hit the roads to protest," he added.

The RJD leader also asked the government to



Leader of the Opposition Tejashwi Yadav meets an injured protester at a hospital in Patna on Sunday. **ANI**

take action against the policemen who opened fire at students at Siwan on Saturday, as well as in Jehanabad on Thursday.

Blaming Mr. Choudhary for the police action, Mr. Tejashwi said, "A person with criminal mentality has been made the Chief Minister in Bihar... He cannot silence the voice of Bihar through the use of *lathis* and the machinery of power."

The RJD leader later visited the hospitals where injured protesters were being treated.

"In a democracy, peaceful protest is an essential right that allows citizens to

express their dissent and ideas, holding unchecked power accountable," he said in a post on X after meeting the protesters.

## 'Minors also arrested'

Disha Students' Organisation member Soma Roy told *The Hindu* that many students have been arrested by the Patna Police, including some minors.

"As many as 11 FIRs have been lodged against protesting students in different police stations in the State since July 22. Some of them are even minors, and their parents contacted me to check about their well-being. The State police must release them immediately as they have been wrongfully detained," Ms. Roy said.

Others who were arrested include Sandeep Saurav, the Communist Party of India (Marxist-Leninist) Liberation's Paliganj MLA and leaders of the AISA State unit, including president Dhananjay.

Youth organisations announced that a Virodh Diwas, or day of protest, will be observed across Bihar on July 30, against the police action and the illegal arrest of student leaders, including the Mr. Saurav.

## 'Foreign extremists' behind violence in Kolkata: Bengal CM

**Shiv Sahay Singh**  
KOLKATA

West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari on Sunday claimed that Islamic fundamentalists, possibly with the backing of foreign forces, had perpetrated the violence during protests in Kolkata on Friday.

Protests against the NEET examination paper leak in Kolkata turned violent on Friday as protesters clashed with the police, prompting security forces to baton charge and fire tear gas shells to disperse the agitators.

The police have arrested 14 persons in connection with the violence. The accused were produced before a city court which remanded them to two days in police custody. The counsel for the accused asked why people had been arrested in Kolkata while no cases were being registered against protesters across the country.

All the cases had been filed by journalists who were assaulted by the protesters, the Chief Minister said. Out of seven cases, six have been filed by journalists. Several journalists were assaulted and heckled by the mob on Friday.

Mr. Adhikari reiterated the protests had nothing to do with the NEET exam



Suwendu Adhikari

paper leak and about 70 persons were identified for their involvement in the violence. "They have nothing to do with the movement. They are not even students. They are Islamic fundamentalists. Investigators are probing whether any foreign force is behind them," he said. Mr. Adhikari had earlier said that the Goonda Act, a new law with provisions for preventive detention of up to 12 months, had been invoked against the accused.

## FIRs against actor

Meanwhile, multiple information reports (FIRs) have been lodged against Bengali actor Sreelekha Mitra across West Bengal on Sunday for allegedly carrying a poster with an objectionable cartoon of Prime Minister Narendra Modi at the students' rally in Kolkata on Friday.

## Odisha BJP leaders criticise post by MP's daughter on Pradhan

**Press Trust of India**  
BHUBANESWAR

A social media post of BJP MP Aparajita Sarangi's daughter Archita Sachin Rahar allegedly celebrating the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan as the Union Education Minister has sparked resentment in the party ranks in Odisha.

Ms. Rahar, in an Instagram post, which had a photograph of Mr. Pradhan in the backdrop of the national flag, wrote, "Dharmendra Pradhan resigns amid massive student protests over NEET leak fiasco." State BJP leaders, including her mother, on the other hand, expressed sympathy for Mr. Pradhan.

Ms. Sarangi, a two-time MP from Bhubaneswar

was, however, unavailable for comment. Sources said the lawmaker had asked her daughter to remove the post after getting a phone call from Mr. Pradhan's office. However, it failed to have an impact.

BJP leaders criticised Ms. Rahar over her post. Jagannath Pradhan, a BJP leader, said, "Mr. Pradhan is son of the soil. His resignation has hurt us. Odias have welcomed the daughter of Bihar (Aparajita) and made her MP twice."

"Ms. Sarangi should have control over her family members. She should tender an apology to Odisha for her daughter making adverse remarks against Mr. Pradhan," he added.

## Assam CM plays down Minister's daughter joining CJP protest in Guwahati

**The Hindu Bureau**  
GUWAHATI

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma has sought to play down the participation of one of his Cabinet Ministers in a Cokroach Janta Party (CJP) protest in Guwahati on July 23.

Revenue and Disaster Management Minister Keshab Mahanta was trotted after videos of his daughter Dibisa Mahanta shouting slogans at a CJP protest against alleged irregularities in the NEET exam went viral.

One of the slogans took a dig at Prime Minister Narendra Modi.



Himanta Biswa Sarma

Mr. Mahanta, a senior leader of the Asom Gana Parishad (AGP), an ally of the BJP in Assam, did not react.

However, the Chief Minister said his Cabinet colleague should not be attacked or trotted for his daughter's action, adding

she "may not follow her father's political ideology".

"Tomorrow, when my son practices law, he may defend someone whom I may not like. The actions of children should not be linked to their parents once they become adults," Mr. Sarma told presspersons on Saturday.

## 'Will speak to her'

"I do not agree with the slogans she raised. When I meet her, I will speak to her about it and try to make her understand that it was not the right thing to say," he said.

Mr. Mahanta is one of two AGP Ministers in the BJP-led Assam government.

## M.P. man booked over 'abusive' reel on Pradhan

**The Hindu Bureau**  
BHOPAL

A social media content creator has been booked in Madhya Pradesh's Niwari district for allegedly using "highly abusive" language against former Union Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, the BJP and the Delhi Police in a video clip amid the student agitation.

According to the police, the accused, Yashpal Soni, a social media influencer, was booked on July 23 over an Instagram reel he had posted and has been questioned in the matter.

Speaking to *The Hindu*, Niwari Superintendent of Police Ray Singh Narwaria said that the video was "way out of the purview of freedom of expression."

## 'Pradhan had offered to quit at start of protest'

**Mehul Malpani**  
BHOHAL

Madhya Pradesh Cabinet Minister and senior BJP leader Kailash Vijayvargya has claimed that Dharmendra Pradhan had offered to resign as the Union Education Minister at the very beginning of the student agitation over the NEET paper leak, but was asked by the party leadership to wait.

Mr. Vijayvargya, a former BJP national general secretary, said in Indore on Saturday that party president Nitin Nabin had asked Mr. Pradhan not to resign until a decision was taken on the matter by the party's top leadership.

He also claimed that Mr. Pradhan's resignation "foiled plans of foreign forces that wanted to create unrest" in India.

## The reframing of the political narrative by Gen Z

## NEWS ANALYSIS

**Sandeep Phukan**  
NEW DELHI

"All is well." The line from *Three Idiots* became an anthem of optimism for an entire generation. The film portrayed the story of three friends trying to break free from the rigid expectations imposed by India's education system.

Aamir Khan played Rancho, whose real identity in the film was Phunsukh Wangdu, an engineer and innovator living in Ladakh. The character was widely believed to have been inspired by innovator-turned-activist Sonam Wangchuk, who later emerged as the face of the anti-paper leak protests at Delhi's Jantar Mantar.

Ironically, the protest site represented the exact inversion of the film's celebrated refrain. Students and young people from diverse social and economic



Protesters celebrate at Jantar Mantar after Dharmendra Pradhan resigned as Education Minister on Saturday. **SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP**

backgrounds gathered to send a simple message: all was not well.

Their objective was not merely to force the government to acknowledge their concerns over recurring examination paper leaks, but also to assert that their individual stories mattered and deserved to be heard.

If the government was the protesters' primary target, a section of the mainstream media became the second. Reporters from television channels were booed and heckled for pro-

moting what the protesters saw as a biased narrative.

For much of the BJP's time in office, critics have accused sections of television news of amplifying the government's narrative. At Jantar Mantar, that criticism found its most visible expression. Posters of several television anchors were displayed, with some protesters branding them "anti-national".

What made the scenes at Jantar Mantar particularly noteworthy was that this sentiment was being artic-

ulated by Gen Z, a generation often perceived as politically detached. Their rejection of sections of the mainstream media ought to prompt introspection within news organisations.

The protesters acquired a sharper political edge after the police action on July 20, involving personnel of the Rapid Action Force and the Delhi Police. Images of students being dragged away and allegations of excessive use of force transformed what began as a movement against paper leaks into a broader expression of youth anxiety about fairness, opportunity and accountability.

"The people of the country have started reclaiming their country back from those who have tried to destroy the Constitution, from those who have tried everything to suppress the voice of the people," Congress leader Priyanka Gandhi Vadra said. Whether or not one agrees with such a political

characterisation, the protests acquired a significance beyond education reform.

## BJP's tasks ahead

Successive electoral victories have given the BJP an aura of political invincibility, encouraging many of its supporters to ridicule the Opposition with ease. But the government quickly recognised the changing mood, opened channels of communication with the leaders of the protest, and signalled that it was willing to engage. Prime Minister Narendra Modi himself reached out to young people through video messages on Instagram, the social media platform most widely used by Gen Z.

The immediate protests may have ended, but the larger political challenge remains. The BJP's task is not merely to resolve the issue of paper leaks. It is to regain the trust of Gen Z, a demographic that has played a crucial role in propelling the party to power.





Workers paint over slogans and graffiti on a wall near Jantar Mantar in New Delhi on Sunday. ANI

## A day later, traces of protest removed from Jantar Mantar

Ashna Butani  
NEW DELHI

On Sunday, posters were brought down and graffiti were covered with paint at Jantar Mantar, which hosted a 36-day agitation that culminated on Saturday with the resignation of former Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan over the NEET question paper leak and other issues.

New Delhi Municipal Corporation (NDMC) officials said that they had conducted a cleanliness and beautification drive at the venue and 60 tonnes of waste had been removed from the site.

The protest drew thousands of protesters, many of them students, and spilled out of Jantar Mantar

on to Tolstoy Road, eventually all the way up to Sansad Marg on one side and Janpath Road on the other. NDMC Vice-Chairperson Kuljeet Singh Chahal said from Saturday night, over 500 officers and employees took part in the drive, undertaking cleaning, washing, repair, and restoration of roads, footpaths, central verges, green belts, walls, and other public spaces.

Seventy-five sanitation workers had been deployed throughout the night, while 35 additional workers joined in the morning. The drive was supported by eight auto-tippers, two heavy trucks, one earthmover, and three high-pressure jetting machines.

# Who approved assault on students, asks Rahul

Congress leader seeks accountability from Home Minister for 'the use of lethal force, including pellet guns' against students in Delhi: Opposition likely to demand PM's apology in Parliament

Sandeep Phukan  
NEW DELHI

The Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, has sought accountability from Union Home Minister Amit Shah for the "barbaric assault on students who were peacefully protesting in Delhi" on July 20. In a letter on Saturday, he asked Mr. Shah whether the latter had authorised the use of "lethal force".

Opposition parties are likely to raise this issue in Parliament on Monday and demand an apology from Prime Minister Narendra Modi, sources told *The Hindu*.

Mr. Gandhi said peaceful protest was crucial to any democracy and it was the government's responsibility to protect protesters and resolve their grievances through dialogue.

The Congress MP said the students were demanding a fair and accountable education system, but instead of being heard, they were assaulted by security forces with indiscriminate force, including lethal weapons and tear gas.



Rahul Gandhi speaks to media on the resignation of Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan in New Delhi on Saturday. @INCINDIA

ons and tear gas.

"Hundreds have suffered serious injuries. Women students have been assaulted by policemen, including by deliberately targeting their private parts. Most shocking has been the use of lethal pellet guns," Mr. Gandhi said in the letter, a copy of which was posted on his X handle on Sunday.

He mentioned meeting 19-year-old student Sahil Lochab, who could lose his eyesight because of pellet gun wounds.

"As Home Minister, did you approve the use of lethal force including pel-

let guns against students? If not, who did? Are the people in plainclothes seen beating students with lathi police personnel or volunteers? Who authorised their deployment?" Mr. Gandhi asked.

On Saturday, the Opposition leader directly blamed the Home Minister for the use of "lethal weapons and pellet guns" in police action.

"We will not accept our own forces shooting the future of India. So, that is going to be a major issue in Parliament," he said.

Other Opposition leaders have also moved a not-

ice under Rule 267 seeking suspension of business to discuss "use of excessive force on student protestors during NEET examination protest". Trinamool Congress's Sagarika Ghosh said, "It is extremely shocking that such extreme coercive measures were taken on unarmed students and youth. Government needs to give us answers on who authorised the use of pellet guns."

Asked if the RAF was authorised to use pellet guns, G.P. Singh, Director-General, Central Reserve Police Force, told *The Hindu*, "Now, since agitation has been called off, and assembled people have dispersed, we would make a professional post-event assessment, like we do after every major assignment, and then let you know the view of the Force Headquarters."

Asked if the Opposition would disrupt proceedings in Parliament, Mr. Gandhi said it would be decided in the meeting of Opposition leaders on Monday morning.

(With inputs from Sobhana K. Nair and Vijaita Singh)

## Students are more important than any post: Home Minister

Press Trust of India  
NEW DELHI

Amit Shah

Union Home Minister Amit Shah has said that the country, youth, and students are far more important than any position for BJP workers and the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan exemplifies this principle.

His remarks came after Mr. Pradhan resigned on Saturday amid mounting pressure from the protests over NEET question paper leak.

"The Modi government respects the sentiments of the country's youth and is committed to implement the necessary reforms against paper leaks," he said in a post on X late on Saturday night.

"For the BJP, the nation, our youth and students hold far greater importance than any position," he said.

The decisions taken by Prime Minister Narendra Modi to ensure strict punishment for those guilty of paper leaks are commendable, Mr. Shah said.

"I am fully confident that these steps will ensure complete justice for the students who succeeded in

the NEET examination," the Home Minister said.

'Significant reforms'

Mr. Shah said Mr. Pradhan had brought about significant reforms in the effective implementation of the National Education Policy (NEP), arrangements for examinations in mother tongues, expansion of PM SHRI Schools, promotion of digital education, skill development, and strengthening industry-academia coordination during his tenure.

"His efforts toward making the examination system more inclusive and student-centric have also been noteworthy. His tenure is a testament to his dedication to the resolve of making India a developed nation," he said.

## At Mumbai rally, people happy with Pradhan's exit, but slam govt. on E20

Snehal Mutha  
MUMBAI

On a rainy Sunday morning, Shubham Shyam, 32, held a *dafali* (traditional hand drum) and stood outside Mumbai's iconic Shivaji Park, celebrating the resignation of Union Minister Dharmendra Pradhan. "It is time to rest, reset, and then take down Union Transport Minister Nitin Gadkari," he declared.

"We will party for two weeks, then we will play the sugarcane game," Mr. Shyam added, hinting at criticism faced by Mr. Gadkari over the implementation of E20, or ethanol-blended petrol. Mr. Shyam's thoughts were echoed by other protesters. Aarsh, 25, a content writer, and Rohan, 19, a B. Tech. student, both said "E20 kills vehicles and people's pockets". Mr. Rohan said, "Since 10th grade, I have seen fuel prices skyrocket, and now vehicle mileage is poor, and pure petrol is expensive. Why give us a cheaper E20 option? Make petrol cheaper," said Mr. Rohan.

"They were participating in a victory rally called by Shiv Sena (UBT) chief Uddhav Thackeray and Maharashtra Navnirman Sena (MNS) chief Raj Thackeray. Thousands of Gen Z and millennials gathered at the rally to celebrate the success of the protest spear-



People at the 'victory rally' at Shivaji Park in Mumbai to celebrate the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

headed by the Cockerroach Janta Party, raising slogans such as "Our right, keep it here", "Bharat Mata Ki Jai", "This country is ours, and we belong to this country," and calling for the resignations of Mr. Gadkari and Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman.

**Uddhav slams PM**  
Mr. Uddhav Thackeray advised Prime Minister Narendra Modi to pay attention to the country, instead of engaging BJP Ministers and MPs to engineer defections. "India has come together, caste, religion, and every other divide is vanishing. It is no more BJP versus the Opposition, but BJP versus the country," said Mr. Thackeray. Mr. Raj Thackeray expressed his gratitude to Mumbai and the Maharashtra Police,

saying, "You are not like the Delhi Police. This is your victory."

Standing next to a row of yellow barricades, animator Mansi Worlikar, 26, and her friends were holding a placard taking a dig at Mr. Modi, who in a recent Instagram video had called the youth his "friends". Ms. Worlikar said, "The victory feels personal, because we fought an impossible mountain and made the crack."

For her friend, entertainment writer Urvasi More, 27, it was an eye-opener that she could have a political opinion, and even voice it. "Something in me has moved; I now know that my political opinion matters," said Ms. More.

Tushar Gandhi, great-grandson of Mahatma Gandhi, also joined the vic-

tory party. He said that the youth of the country had chosen their path. "However, the challenge is to make every issue a mass issue and not allow the government to confine it to a particular community, caste, or economic group," Mr. Gandhi added.

'Showing up matters'

The party atmosphere appeared complete, with Bluetooth speakers belting out popular Hindi songs and the Gen Z swaying to the music. In one such group stood Tarini, 23, who said, "We are not saying the system has changed, but there is hope for change. Showing up does matter."

For Anam Khan, 21, a teacher from Sion, the protest felt like a lesson on humanity. "I never felt this equal with Hindus, Jains, or any other community. We saw instances where we were about to get detained and ran holding each other's hands without thinking whether the other person was Hindu or Muslim. That is the beauty I saw here."

Gia, 23, said, "The result is a cosmetic makeover, but at least now we know people in India vote with emotions. But we will vote logically, on facts."

This is a new beginning in seeking accountability from our leaders, Ms. Tarini added.

## Hunger strike was challenge to govt., the movement is still on, says AISA secretary

Sobhana K. Nair  
NEW DELHI

Six of them sat on a hunger strike, a little away from the main dais at Jantar Mantar where the spotlight was on activist Sonam Wangchuk. Three of the six were still around when Mr. Wangchuk was forcibly shifted to hospital by the police on July 18. On July 25, when Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan announced his resignation, they were still there at the protest venue.

The members of the All India Students' Association (AISA) had sat there for 23 days, as doctors took their blood pressure, conducted ECGs, and pricked their arms for blood tests.

The AISA was among the many student organisations reached out by the Cockerroach Janta Party (CJP), which headlined the protests against exam question paper leaks. Other Left student bodies were also associated with the protests, including the Students Federation of India (SFI), the All India Students Federation (AISF), and the Krantikari Yuva Sangathan (KYS). Many in the Left circles questioned the political affiliations of this newly minted organisation, the CJP, born on social media. Many dismissed it as a



Neha

"pressure valve" that would function to dissipate the discontent.

Neha, Delhi secretary of AISA, the student body of the Communist Party of India (ML) Liberation, said that her organisation too was cautious. She was among the three AISA activists who sat on the hunger strike. But the apprehensions were set aside for two reasons. One, she said, "if those of us with experience of running mass movements such as these are around, we won't allow anyone to hijack the agenda." Second, this protest held great potential to reach out to young people who have so far been served only communal politics, she said.

During those 23 days, though her stomach was empty, her heart was filled, with people walking up to her. "Many of them came to me apologising,

saying that I had to go hungry since they voted for the BJP. Many even cried." The experience that has stayed with her is that of the weeping father of a NEET student who died by suicide. "He said he had voted for the BJP and made everyone in his family vote for the BJP," Ms. Neha said.

'Not about self-sacrifice'

"It was never about self-sacrifice. It was rather a challenge to the government. The question was: will the government let us waste away slowly rather than forcing their Minister to resign?" She said that Mr. Pradhan's resignation was only the first of the many to come. The protest at Jantar Mantar may have ended but the movement has not, she said.

The SFI and AISF sat on hunger strike from July 18-20. SFI president Adarsh M. Saji said his organisation's idea was to take the protest beyond Jantar Mantar. "We organised protests in 24 States," he said.

"We didn't have any confusion about the ultimate goal of this protest. It was clear that it went beyond slogans; it was an agitation to regain democratic space that has been ceded in the last 12 years," CPI(M) Rajya Sabha leader John Brittas said.

## RSS women's wing seeks uniform policy on population

Ishita Mishra  
NEW DELHI

The Rashtra Sevika Samiti, the women's parallel of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), on Sunday adopted a resolution expressing concern over what it termed "population imbalance" in the country, urging the Centre and State governments to formulate a uniform national population policy applicable to all communities.

The resolution was passed at the organisation's Akhil Bharatiya Pratidin Sabha (All India Representative Council), held at Samalakra and was headed by Samiti chief V. Shantha Kumari.

Arguing that population was not merely a statistical measure but determined a nation's future and identity, the resolution stated that while India's population growth rate had declined due to decades of population control measures, demographic changes among religious communities had created an imbalance that warranted a review of the existing population policy.

"The growing demographic imbalance in India is not only eroding the country's identity but is also posing a threat to India's very existence," the resolution read.

## Sonam Wangchuk to be discharged from hospital today; will visit Rajghat

Press Trust of India  
NEW DELHI

Activist Sonam Wangchuk will be discharged from Medanta Hospital in Gurugram on Monday and will visit Rajghat to pay homage to Mahatma Gandhi before leaving for Ladakh, his team said.

Mr. Wangchuk, who is recovering in the hospital after he broke his 26-day fast late Friday night, is expected to be dis-

charged at around 11.30 am on Monday.

He had paid homage to Mahatma Gandhi at Rajghat, on June 28, before launching his indefinite hunger strike at Jantar Mantar here to support students protesting alleged irregularities, such as question paper leak, in the recently held NEET medical entrance examination. Mr. Wangchuk had joined the agitation on June 28 and remained on an indefinite fast for

26 days. He was forcibly shifted to Safdarjung Hospital on July 18, where he said he felt like he was being kept in detention. Following a Delhi High Court order, he was shifted to Medanta Hospital.

The 36-day agitation, led by the Cockerroach Janta Party (CJP), ended on Saturday with the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan as Union Education Minister. The protest had begun on June 20.

**KERALA WATER AUTHORITY**  
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1. Design, Construction, Commissioning, Trial Running, Operation and Maintenance (for a period of 5 years) of 5 MLD capacity STP at Alappuzha District along with Design, Construction, Testing and Commissioning of 11.88 km sewage collection network in ward No.34 and 35 (M) of Alappuzha Municipality and allied works. Cost of tender form: Rs. 15,130/- (inclusive of GST) 1540. Rs. 5,000/00/- (Date and time of Opening tender: 01/09/2026 at 3.30 pm. Last date of receipt of tender: 31/08/2026 at 3.30 pm. Phone: 8547638592; E-mail: [sandipgopinathan@kwa.org.in](mailto:sandipgopinathan@kwa.org.in)  
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The Superintending Engineer, Electrical Circle (R&B) Odisha, Bhubaneswar on behalf of the Governor of Odisha invites percentage rate bids for E.L. works which are to be received through online bidding, double cover system as detailed in: <https://tenders.orissa.gov.in>. The details of bid documents will be available in the above website from 23.07.2026 at 05.00 P.M. to 24.08.2026 up to 05.00 P.M. The bidders must possess compatible Digital Signature Certificate of Class II or III. Bids received online shall be opened at 14.08.2026 at 11.30 A.M. in the Office of the Superintending Engineer, Electrical Circle (R&B) Odisha, Bhubaneswar. Further details can be seen from the e-procurement portal [www.tenders.orissa.gov.in](http://www.tenders.orissa.gov.in). Addendum / Corrigendum, if required, will be available only in the Website.  
Superintending Engineer,  
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OPR-24001/14006/1126-27/2022

## IN BRIEF



## Assam flood toll hits 66; CM asks BJP workers to give donations

The ruling BJP government in Assam has sought funds from its party workers to provide relief to flood-affected people, as the death toll reached 66 by Saturday night. On Sunday, Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma announced that clothes would be distributed to 4 lakh women and children from Sivasagar, Charaideo, Jorhat, and Golaghat, the four severely affected districts, in that order. "The BJP will require ₹12 crore to undertake this relief measure. I appeal to our party workers in and outside Assam to contribute to this noble cause," he said. Mr. Sarma advised BJP workers to hand over donations of up to ₹2,000 to the local MLA.

## 3 Great Indian Bustard chicks placed in rewinding tunnel

In a first, three chicks of the endangered Great Indian Bustard have been moved into a custom-built rewinding tunnel at the Godawan Conservation Centre in Ramdevra, Jaipur. The ₹9.25-crore facility prepares captive-bred birds for life in the wild by minimising human contact and copying their natural habitat. The Great Indian Bustard is the State bird of Rajasthan. The chicks will remain in the tunnel for about four months under CCTV surveillance. The food will be provided without direct human contact. Following the rewinding phase, the chicks will be released into Desert National Park. PH

## BJP using unfair campaign practices ahead of Bankipur bypoll, says Kishor

Amit Bhelari  
PATNA

Ahead of the Bankipur bypoll scheduled for July 30, founder of the Jan Suraj Party (JSP) and its candidate for the bypoll Prashant Kishor launched a scathing attack on the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Sunday.

The BJP was using the district administration to harass his party leaders and deploying 'Jeevika Didi' for campaigning, Mr. Kishor alleged. He would undertake a sit-in protest outside the office of the State Election Commission if these practices were not stopped within 24 hours, Mr. Kishor said.

Patna District Magistrate Kundan Kumar, in an official post on Saturday, "once again repeated the same objectionable practice we witnessed in November 2025", he said.

Under the guise of promoting voter awareness,



Jan Suraj Party founder Prashant Kishor in Patna on Sunday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Jeevika Didi, who are employed by the State government, were tasked with telling women that they would stop receiving welfare benefits, including ration and pension, if they did not vote for the ruling National Democratic Alliance or the BJP, Mr. Kishor alleged.

**'DM must issue order'**  
"It is not enough for the DM (District Magistrate) to simply delete a tweet (social media post). He must issue an order stating that no woman associated with

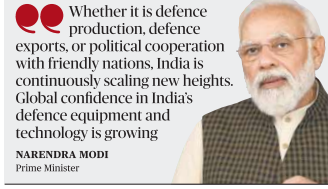
The Hindu Bureau  
NEW DELHI

India is continuously scaling new heights in defence production, defence exports, and political cooperation with friendly nations, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said on Sunday in the latest episode of *Mann Ki Baat*, his monthly radio address.

Mr. Modi also paid tributes to the soldiers who sacrificed their lives during the Kargil War in 1999.

India was continuously strengthening its technological capabilities, he said. Citing the induction of INS *Mahendragiri* into the Indian Navy, he said the modern warship had been designed and built in India. More than 75% of the materials used in it are indigenous. "It is a symbol of the growing strength of an 'Atmanirbhar Bharat'." This very month, the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) also successfully tested the Pinaka Long-Range Guided Rocket. Behind this success lies the collective perseverance of our scientists and engineers. The DRDO

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://t.me/+8B98m5PQCF84MmQ9>



NARENDRA MODI  
Prime Minister

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://t.me/+8B98m5PQCF84MmQ9> also successfully tested the Kasha missile," he said. "Whether it is defence production, defence exports, or political cooperation with friendly nations, India is continuously scaling new heights. Earlier this month, I was in Indonesia, where a major agreement regarding BrahMos and Astra missiles was concluded. Global confidence in India's defence equipment and technology is growing," Mr. Modi said.

## Remarkable feats

Wishing the Indian contingent the very best for the Commonwealth Games, which began in Glasgow a few days ago, the Prime Minister said people across the country hoped that the

Shakti' has brought glory to the nation there," he said.

Mr. Modi said "our young friends" were also bringing glory to India in the field of science. "Olympiads in Physics, Chemistry, Biology, and Mathematics were held just this month. The Indian contingent delivered a spectacular performance in these competitions. In the Physics Olympiad, all five of our students won gold medals, and India secured the top rank," he said.

"In the Chemistry Olympiad, too, all our students won gold medals. All our students also won medals in the Biology Olympiad, including a gold medal. In the Mathematics Olympiad, our students secured two gold and four silver medals. I am immensely proud of the nation's youth power. It is heartening to see the culture of Olympiads and Hackathons steadily growing in India. I am confident that more and more young people across the country will show interest in such forums and keep the flag of India flying high," he said.

## Inflation control remains RBI's foremost priority, says Governor

Raghuvir Srinivasan  
Thomas K Thomas  
K. Ram Kumar  
Mahesh Ravidas Nayak  
MUMBAI

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI)'s recent measures to attract foreign capital have garnered strong investor response, with banks mobilising nearly \$32 billion, largely through Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank), or FCNRI, deposits, while government securities have attracted more than \$7 billion in foreign inflows since the June policy measures, RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra has said.

In an interview with *The Hindu BusinessLine*, Mr. Malhotra dismissed concerns that the inflows merely represent a recycling of existing deposits. He added that the RBI has adequate tools to manage any resulting liquidity. The inflows have strengthened



Sanjay Malhotra

India's external position amid heightened geopolitical uncertainty and volatile global capital flows, he said.

Responding to concerns over the RBI bearing the hedging cost of fresh FCNR (B) deposits and offering concessional forex swaps for external commercial borrowings (ECBs) by public sector entities, Mr. Malhotra said: "It is not something which should be a matter of concern because

## Youth have decisive role in shaping the future of India: Modi

Saurabh Trivedi  
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday urged young Indians to play a constructive role in nation-building by connecting with border villages through the Viksit Vibrant Village Programme 2026.

He expressed confidence that India's youth would play a decisive role in shaping the country's future. He said that when young people connect directly with the nation's challenges and opportunities, the country's future becomes stronger and brighter. The statement comes a day after youth-led protests forced Dharmendra Pradhan to resign as the Education Minister.

Interacting with participants of the programmes, Mr. Modi welcomed youth representatives from around 250 districts and praised the growing reach of the Mera Yuva Bharat (MY Bharat) platform, which, he said, has expanded to include crores of young citizens engaged in national development initiatives.

Highlighting the role of the youth in shaping India's future, Mr. Modi said

MY Bharat volunteers have demonstrated their capabilities through programmes such as the Viksit Bharat Dialogue and the Viksit Vibrant Village Programme.

He said connecting young people with the realities of rural and border regions helps broaden their understanding of the nation and strengthens their commitment to public service.

Recalling the programme's origins during the Viksit Bharat Young Leaders Dialogue, Mr. Modi said more than 400 youth were selected from nearly three lakh applicants to visit border villages in Himachal Pradesh, Uttarakhand, and Ladakh.

The initiative, he said, was designed to introduce participants to local culture, understand the aspirations of border communities, and witness the dedication of India's armed forces.

Emphasising the importance of border villages in India's development journey, Mr. Modi said the government's approach has shifted from treating them as the country's "last villages" to recognising them as the "first villages" of India.

we have a foolproof system of insuring ourselves. So, whatever dollars we get, the excess foreign currency is invested in foreign assets."

Mr. Malhotra said the measures should be viewed in the context of challenging global conditions facing emerging markets and are expected to further strengthen India's balance of payments and currency stability.

**'Rupee not overvalued'**  
Mr. Malhotra also sought to reassure markets on the rupee, arguing that recent depreciation does not reflect any weakness in the country's economic fundamentals. According to him, pressure on the currency has largely stemmed from geopolitical tensions, dollar strength and broader volatility across emerging markets.

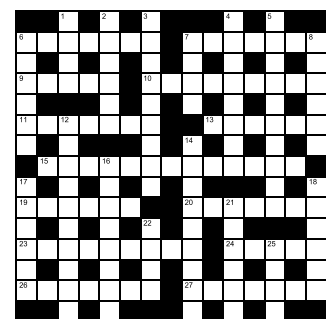
"We do not target any specific exchange rate or

band for the rupee. Our intervention, whenever necessary, is targeted to curb excessive volatility," he said, adding that the currency is "not overvalued" and could even be considered undervalued in both nominal and real effective exchange rate terms.

On monetary policy, Mr. Malhotra reiterated that inflation control remains the RBI's foremost priority even as it remains mindful of growth risks. He said the Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) will continue to adopt a data-dependent approach while navigating the evolving growth-inflation trade-off.

"Our primary mandate is inflation and price stability. Therefore, we will do whatever is required first, to keep price stability and then, to see to what extent we can support growth," he said.

(The writers are with *The Hindu BusinessLine*)

THE CROSSWORD 14856  
(set by Bruno)

## Across

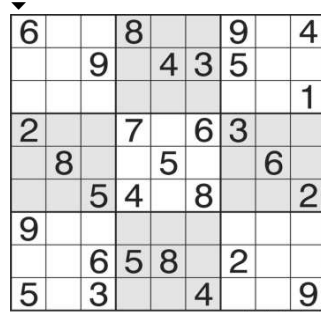
- 6 College's appeal to get girl fired causes uproar (7)
- 7 Uptat as Southern township disappears mysteriously (7)
- 9 Artificial intelligence confuses oil for sauce (5)
- 10 Yahoo taken in by scoundrel here regularly, that bird-brain! (9)
- 11 Green sea bubbles round America — with no form (7)
- 13 Improve menu by removing first item — and putting in place on the counter (4,2)

- 15 Engine's top injures people often, when falling (3,10)
- 19 Communist seems exposed giving pay off (6)
- 20 City girl mostly surrounded by girls outside work (7)
- 23 Encourage counterfeit notes, essentially to be hidden (9)
- 24 It might bait out one? (5)
- 26 Hint of hardness in one building material (7)
- 27 With Siri, this Christmas symbol can be arranged religiously (4,3)

## Down

- 1 Root of black oppression, mainly (4)
- 2 One could start a chain reaction in fashion — I'm oddly aroused (6)
- 3 Rigour in case of emergency arising during prison riots (9)
- 4 Jars of drinks containing fish (5,3)
- 5 Dancer's goal — release a sad lullaby (10)
- 6 Mission: convert neutral to become radical (6)
- 7 One money for all boomerangs (4)
- 8 Free of former partner's influence, sweetheart's finally liberated (6)
- 12 One has to stay under that quietly during idle times, perhaps (5,5)
- 14 Famous psychiatrist's support led to setter's recovery — it's a childhood thing (6,3)
- 16 Jump to conclusion that half of jury is consumed by power and greed when assembled (8)
- 17 Credit is India's major problem (6)
- 18 Morning — daylight's beginning to come off canopy (6)
- 19 Fertile horse with large, great heart (6)
- 22 Very alcoholic drink... causes depression (4)
- 25 Lazy creep avoids society (4)

## SUDOKU



DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

## Solution to previous puzzle



## Solution to yesterday's Sudoku



## FAITH

## Life lessons from Ramayana

Epics and various holy texts not only educate but also elevate a person's mental and spiritual well-being and should be perused daily. A reading of the Ramayana, for example, is recommended for one at any stage in life. The Ramayana is a treatise on so many aspects of life. It showcases devotion; highlights how to pursue dharma in everyday life. It is also a commentary on the ideal family, said Damodara Deekshithar. It is a commentary on family structure, and nothing much has changed since the time Perumal manifested as Rama. The structure remains the same and many challenges in life are similar: the way parents interact with one another, the manner in which a spouse conducts himself or herself, the way siblings react to a situation and the reaction of children to various challenges. In the material world, one always struggles to balance the family with right conduct (dharma). What the Ramayana imparts is a unique lesson. When Kaikeyi tells Rama, "Your father told me to tell you to go to the forest," Rama politely interjected at once saying, "You do not have to say my father said so... even someone on the road can tell me," and immediately starts making preparation to honour the banishment orchestrated by Kaikeyi, in order to gain the kingdom for her own son, Bharata.

When Dasaratha bemoans the turn of events, Kausalya tells him, "Why are you getting agitated now? You wanted to keep Kaikeyi happy, therefore you banished Rama." Dasaratha then says he has sinned and brought about this unbearable parting from son upon himself.

In the Mahabharata, Vyasa says one should not let go of dharma under any circumstances.



# MONEYWISE

## Sold your car? Ensure ownership transfer

### COVERNOTE



One can't simply hand over the keys, collect the money and move on. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

K. Nityakalyani

Apparently, nightmares come in a few familiar forms: turning up unprepared for an examination, desperately trying to reach somewhere on time or you/your loved ones being threatened, chased or attacked.

Receiving a court summons in a motor accident compensation case involving your vehicle. The one you sold five years ago.

Ok, that one may not feature in psychology textbooks. But it is certainly a nightmare you do not want to experience.

A relative of mine did. Almost. Last week, he received a traffic challan for a car he had sold years ago. Alarmed, he logged on to the Ministry of Road Transport and Highways Parivahan portal, only to discover that the vehicle was still registered in his name. The buyer had never completed the transfer of the Registration Certificate (RC). That meant that legally my relative was still responsible for anything to do with the vehicle.

The discovery was enough to ruin his week. And mine. Because his next outreach was to me.

### The mighty paperwork

There is an old saying: "It's not done till the paperwork is done". Nowhere is this truer than when selling a vehicle.

You cannot simply hand over the keys, the RC and the transfer forms, collect the money and move on. Until the ownership transfer is completed, you remain exposed.

Here is what should be done. Both buyer and seller must sign Forms 29 and 30 clearly mentioning the date of sale and each should retain an original. The buyer should clearly be named with address, mobile number and an identify proof. This fixes the timeframe for transfer and identifies the buyer.

Brokers many a time take over the vehicle claiming they are the buyers and then hunt for customers. That is why they will cajole you into signing blank forms. Please don't.

The seller, you should send a letter to your RTO, saying you have sold the vehicle and disclaiming any further liability. Attach copies of Forms 29 and 30, the identity proof of the buyer and sale proof. Send it by Speed Post, preserve the receipt, track the delivery online and keep proof of delivery safely.

To be fair, my relative had done everything required. Except check if the actual transfer had taken place.

### Not a first

Sadly, this is not an isolated case. I have heard several such stories. I have faced it myself.

One friend discovered that a vehicle he had long since sold had been implicated in an illegal drugs case. Imagine receiving notice in a fatal accident claim.

Point of sale formalities apart, the system itself needs improvement. Both buyer and seller should be able to track the ownership transfer online, and automatic alerts should be sent to them, and to the authorities, whenever a transfer remains incomplete beyond a reasonable period.

In an age of digital records, instant communication and online services, this is not too much to ask.

If the police can send us a traffic challan by SMS within seconds of a violation, surely our transport system can tell us when ownership of a vehicle worth several lakh rupees has not changed hands.

(The writer is a business journalist specialising in insurance & corporate history)



The lifecycle of an electronic gold receipt ends when the owner opts for physical delivery. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

## What's behind the vault of India's gold exchange

Every electronic gold receipt has a story before it reaches your portfolio; a journey from physical gold through vaults, depositories and stock exchanges, it can change hands countless times

### VAULT VOYAGE

Vaishali R Venkat

The life of every Electronic Gold Receipt (EGR) begins and ends with physical gold. Between these two points lies a carefully choreographed journey. Before an EGR lands in your demat account, physical gold must first pass through a tightly regulated ecosystem that verifies the metal, creates the receipt and enables trading on the exchange.

### Why a gold exchange?

For decades, India's physical gold trade largely took place through jewellers, bullion dealers and over-the-counter transactions. While gold itself was standardised, trading remained fragmented. Despite accounting for a large share of global gold consumption, India lacked a nationwide exchange for trading standardised physical gold, with prices varying across markets/states.

The EGRs were introduced to bridge this gap. The Gold Exchange provides a national platform for trading standardised physical gold, facilitates transparent price discovery, improves liquidity and assures the quality of gold.

### Creation of an EGR

The journey begins when the owner of eligible physical gold deposits it with a vault manager registered



The lifecycle of an EGR ends when the beneficial owner opts for physical delivery: the vault manager hands over the gold upon request

with the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) for conversion into EGRs. Only eligible gold sourced through imports or exchange-accredited domestic refineries can be converted.

The gold is weighed, assayed and verified, after which the vault manager records the deposit in the common interface and no EGR can be created unless it is backed by the corresponding physical gold in the vault. The EGR is then credited to the beneficial owner's demat account and made tradeable on the stock exchange by the Depository. The vault manager and the Depository regularly reconcile EGR records with the underlying physical gold, while the Depository also conducts periodic inspections of the vaulted gold.

### Trading of an EGR

The moment an EGR enters a demat account, it sheds the identity of the gold bar and begins a life of its own. Unlike physical gold, it can change hands countless times without a single gram moving out of the vault. Behind the scenes, the Depos-



If a dispute over the quality of the gold arises at the time of withdrawal, it is resolved through an empanelled assayer

itory keeps the exchanges and clearing corporations updated on newly created EGRs, while the clearing corporation ensures seamless settlement between the buyer and the seller.

### Fungibility

Once an EGR is created, it is no longer tied to a particular gold bar. Instead, it represents a standard quantity and purity of gold. So, when an investor converts an EGR into physical gold, they receive gold of the same specifications, and not necessarily the very bar that was originally deposited. This feature, known as fungibility, works together with inter-operability, allowing investors, wherever possible, to collect their gold from a different eligible vault location instead of returning to the vault where it was originally deposited.

### Conversion

The lifecycle of an EGR ends when the owner opts for physical delivery. On receiving the request through the Depository, the vault manager hands over the gold and simultaneously extinguishes the correspond-

ing EGR. The Depository then updates the stock exchanges and clearing corporations to keep their records in sync.

### The EGR ecosystem

Unlike physical gold transactions that typically involve only a buyer and a seller, the EGR brings together multiple regulated entities. Vault managers safeguard the gold, Depositories maintain electronic ownership records, stock exchanges facilitate trading, clearing corporations settle transactions, brokers connect investors to the market, while eligible gold depositors create EGRs and investors trade.

### Should EGRs be part of your portfolio?

EGRs are certainly not a replacement for jewellery. Whether they will emerge as a viable alternative to Gold ETFs remains to be seen. EGRs combine the convenience of trading electronically while retaining the option of taking physical delivery of gold.

Every new investment avenue attracts early enthusiasm. Before climbing onto the EGR bandwagon, investors should first understand the framework behind it. After all, informed investing begins with understanding the product. Knowledge must precede participation.

(The writer is an NISM & CRISIL-certified Wealth Manager and certified in NISM's Research Analyst module)

## How passionate are you about your collectibles?

### THINKINVESTOR

We typically focus on what we have to give up when we sell the assets than the gains that we can generate by selling them

Venkatesh Bangaruswamy

Previously in this column, we discussed about passion assets. This refers to assets that are collectibles such as paintings and antiques. Passion assets are both consumption and investment assets. That is, you can enjoy them as collectibles and later sell the assets to generate gains. In this article, we discuss the risks associated with such assets, especially the pain of parting with them.

When we own a collectible, we typically focus on what we have to give-up when we sell the asset than the gains we can generate by selling them. This explains why we want a higher price when we sell an asset we own than if we want to buy the same asset when we do not own it. Behavioural psychologists refer to this as the endowment effect. Think of it as the pain premium. At the extreme, you may be unwilling to part with an asset even if the offer price is good. Unless you sell these assets, they are just personal collectibles, not passion assets. So, the primary risk is that you may never realize gains on such assets during your lifetime.

Fortunately, time is a beneficial factor. The longer you own an asset, the more willing you may be to part with it. You may be unwilling to sell your first collectible you acquired, say, 20 years ago and your recent acquisition. But you may be less reluctant to part with the ones you acquired, say, ten years ago. Sometimes, you may be willing to sell from your old collection when you acquire a similar asset with better provenance. Typically, a large collection of passion assets is sold when the legal heirs clear the estate of a collector. To ensure that your legal heirs eventually get good value for your passion assets, you must document each asset's provenance, whenever possible. This refers to dating the age of the asset, the date of acquisition, its price and the source of acquisition (a dealer or a private collector). Remember, narrative adds value to an asset. A 100-year rosewood barley-twist desk may fetch a significantly higher price if it were sourced from a colonial-era palace or from a well-known personality than from an unknown private home. Finally, you must ensure your assets are well-preserved. Direct sunlight can harm rare and vintage paintings. Managing these risks can enhance the value of your passion assets.

(The author offers training programmes for individuals to manage their personal investments)

### Bank Fixed Deposit Rates

| Bank Name                   | Interest Rates (%) |               |               |               |
|-----------------------------|--------------------|---------------|---------------|---------------|
|                             | Highest Slab       | 1-year Tenure | 3-year Tenure | 5-year Tenure |
| <b>Small Finance Banks</b>  |                    |               |               |               |
| AU Small Finance Bank       | 7.40               | 6.35          | 7.40          | 6.75          |
| Equitas Small Finance Bank  | 8.00               | 7.10          | 7.10          | 7.00          |
| ESAF Small Finance Bank     | 7.75               | 6.00          | 6.00          | 5.75          |
| Jana Small Finance Bank     | 8.00               | 7.00          | 8.00          | 7.77          |
| Shivalik Small Finance Bank | 8.00               | 6.00          | 7.50          | 6.25          |
| slice Small Finance Bank    | 7.75               | 6.25          | 7.50          | 7.00          |
| Suryoday Small Finance Bank | 8.10               | 7.25          | 7.25          | 7.90          |
| Ujjivan Small Finance Bank  | 7.80               | 7.25          | 7.25          | 7.20          |
| Utkarsh Small Finance Bank  | 8.10               | 6.00          | 7.50          | 7.00          |
| <b>Private Sector Banks</b> |                    |               |               |               |
| Axis Bank                   | 6.50               | 6.25          | 6.50          | 6.50          |
| Bandhan Bank                | 7.45               | 7.00          | 7.25          | 5.85          |
| City Union Bank             | 7.25               | 6.65          | 6.50          | 6.55          |
| CSB Bank                    | 7.35               | 5.00          | 5.75          | 5.75          |
| DPS Bank                    | 6.85               | 6.30          | 6.40          | 6.25          |
| DCB Bank                    | 7.50               | 6.90          | 7.00          | 7.50          |
| Federal Bank                | 6.70               | 6.25          | 6.40          | 6.40          |
| HDFC Bank                   | 6.50               | 6.25          | 6.45          | 6.40          |
| ICICI Bank                  | 6.50               | 6.25          | 6.45          | 6.50          |
| IDFC FIRST Bank             | 7.35               | 6.50          | 7.35          | 6.75          |
| IndusInd Bank               | 7.00               | 6.75          | 7.00          | 6.65          |

| Bank Name                  | Interest Rates (%) |               |               |               |
|----------------------------|--------------------|---------------|---------------|---------------|
|                            | Highest Slab       | 1-year Tenure | 3-year Tenure | 5-year Tenure |
| <b>Public Sector Banks</b> |                    |               |               |               |
| Jammu & Kashmir Bank       | 7.30               | 6.80          | 6.80          | 6.85          |
| IDBI Bank                  | 6.50               | 6.20          | 6.35          | 6.25          |
| Karnataka Bank             | 7.00               | 6.50          | 6.15          | 6.15          |
| Kotak Mahindra Bank        | 6.80               | 6.35          | 6.40          | 6.25          |
| RBL Bank                   | 7.20               | 7.00          | 7.20          | 6.70          |
| SBI Bank India             | 7.35               | 7.35          | 7.10          | 7.00          |
| South Indian Bank          | 6.80               | 6.25          | 6.20          | 5.70          |
| Tamilnad Mercantile Bank   | 7.25               | 6.80          | 6.70          | 6.70          |
| YES Bank                   | 7.25               | 6.65          | 7.00          | 6.75          |
| <b>Public Sector Banks</b> |                    |               |               |               |
| Bank of Baroda             | 6.75               | 6.25          | 6.25          | 6.30          |
| Bank of India              | 6.85               | 6.50          | 6.70          | 6.00          |
| Bank of Maharashtra        | 6.65               | 6.40          | 5.25          | 5.00          |
| Canara Bank                | 6.60               | 6.25          | 6.25          | 6.25          |
| Central Bank of India      | 6.70               | 6.10          | 6.00          | 6.00          |
| Indian Bank                | 6.80               | 6.10          | 6.05          | 6.00          |
| Indian Overseas Bank       | 6.60               | 6.50          | 6.10          | 6.10          |
| Punjab National Bank       | 6.60               | 6.25          | 6.30          | 6.35          |
| Punjab & Sind Bank         | 6.85               | 5.85          | 5.85          | 5.95          |
| State Bank of India        | 6.45               | 6.25          | 6.30          | 6.05          |
| Union Bank of India        | 6.65               | 6.20          | 6.10          | 6.00          |

### Home Loan Interest Rates

| Name of Lender              | Loan Amount (Rs.) |                              |               |        |
|-----------------------------|-------------------|------------------------------|---------------|--------|
|                             | Upto 30 lakh      | Above 30 lakh & upto 75 lakh | Above 75 lakh | (On %) |
| <b>Public Sector Banks</b>  |                   |                              |               |        |
| State Bank of India         | 7.25-9.05         | 7.25-9.05                    | 7.25-9.05     |        |
| Bank of Baroda              | 7.20-9.00         | 7.20-9.00                    | 7.20-9.25     |        |
| Union Bank of India*        | 7.15-9.60         | 7.15-9.60                    | 7.15-9.60     |        |
| Punjab National Bank        | 7.30-9.30         | 7.25-9.20                    | 7.25-9.20     |        |
| Bank of India               | 7.10-10.00        | 7.10-10.00                   | 7.10-10.25    |        |
| UCO Bank**                  | 7.15-9.25         | 7.15-9.25                    | 7.15-9.25     |        |
| Punjab and Sind Bank        | 7.30-10.70        | 7.30-10.70                   | 7.30-10.70    |        |
| Indian Overseas Bank        | 7.20              | 7.20                         | 7.20          |        |
| Indian Bank                 | 7.15-9.55         | 7.15-9.55                    | 7.15-9.55     |        |
| Central Bank of India       | 7.10-9.15         | 7.10-9.15                    | 7.10-9.15     |        |
| <b>Private Sector Banks</b> |                   |                              |               |        |
| Kotak Mahindra Bank         | 7.60              | 7.60                         | 7.60          |        |
| ICICI Bank                  | 7.50              | 7.50                         | 7.50          |        |
| Axis Bank                   | 8.00-11.90        | 8.00-11.90                   | 8.00-9.10     |        |
| HSBC Bank                   | 7.45              | 7.45                         | 7.45          |        |
| South Indian Bank           | 7.20              | 7.20                         | 7.20          |        |
| Karur Vysya Bank            | 8.50-10.65        | 8.50-10.65                   | 8.50-10.65    |        |
| Karnataka Bank              | 7.45-11.72        | 7.45-11.72                   | 7.45-11.72    |        |
| Federal Bank                | 8.35-10.25        | 8.35-10.25                   | 7.35-9.25     |        |

| Name of Lender                          | Loan Amount (Rs.) |                              |               |        |
|-----------------------------------------|-------------------|------------------------------|---------------|--------|
|                                         | Upto 30 lakh      | Above 30 lakh & upto 75 lakh | Above 75 lakh | (On %) |
| <b>Tamilnad Mercantile Bank</b>         |                   |                              |               |        |
| Bandhan Bank                            | 7.90-9.30         | 7.90-9.30                    | 7.90-9.30     |        |
| RBL Bank                                | 8.20              | 8.20                         | 8.20          |        |
| CSB Bank                                | 8.30              | 8.30                         | 8.30          |        |
| HDFC Bank                               | 7.75              | 7.75                         | 7.75          |        |
| City Union Bank                         | 8.25-9.50         | 8.50-10.00                   | 8.75-10.50    |        |
| <b>Housing Finance Companies (HFCs)</b> |                   |                              |               |        |
| LIC Housing Finance                     | 7.15              | 7.15                         | 7.15          |        |
| Bajaj Housing Finance                   | 7.25              | 7.25                         | 7.25          |        |
| Tata Capital                            | 8.00              | 8.00                         | 8.00          |        |
| PNB Housing Finance                     | 7.50              | 7.50                         | 7.50          |        |
| GIC Housing Finance                     | 8.20              | 8.20                         | 8.20          |        |
| SMFG India Home Finance                 | 9.25              | 9.25                         | 9.25          |        |
| Sammam Capital                          | 8.75              | 8.75                         | 8.75          |        |
| Aditya Birla Capital                    | 7.75              | 7.75                         | 7.75          |        |
| ICICI Home Finance                      | 7.50              | 7.50                         | 7.50          |        |
| Godrej Housing Finance                  | 7.65              | 7.65                         | 7.65          |        |

\*Extra 0.05% rate concession to borrowers taking insurance  
\*\*Additional concession of 0.05% & 0.10% for women borrowers and takeover loans, respectively  
#Onwards Rates as on July 22 Source: Paisabazaar.com

BERLIN

Chief suspect in Berlin Pride attack killed in confrontation with police



The suspect in the Berlin Pride attack that left one person dead and 29 injured was shot and killed by police on Sunday, authorities said. Abdul Ballout who was suspected of driving a van into a crowd was killed after a search that lasted nearly 24 hours. Prosecutors said he had previously sought to join the Islamic State group. AP

LONDON

New U.K. PM vows to put 'Britain's interest first' in ties with Trump



U.K. Prime Minister Rishi Sunak has said he may "take a different opinion" from U.S. President Donald Trump and will "put Britain's interest first" when dealing with the American leader. In excerpts released on Sunday at a BBC interview, Mr. Sunak also insisted he would "of course" be willing to call Mr. Trump out if needed. AFP

CUBA

Cuban leader accuses Washington of seeking to 'appropriate' island



Cuban President Miguel Diaz-Canel denounced on Sunday Washington's pressure campaign against his country as a "genocidal policy," accusing the U.S. of seeking to "appropriate" the island. "The [decades-long embargo and oil] blockade is a weapon of war and it causes deaths," the President said. AFP

WASHINGTON

Trump is giving Iran talks 'some space'; no munition issue: Waltz



U.S. President Donald Trump is giving negotiations with Iran "some space," Mike Waltz, U.S. Ambassador to the UN, said on Sunday. He dismissed reports that the Washington was rationing munitions over supply concerns. The U.S. remained "locked and loaded" for more attacks, with additional assets moved into the region, he said.

Israeli settlers set fire to mosques in West Bank following deadly clashes

Incident escalated after a settler group descended on the Palestinian village; local people say graffiti in mosque called for revenge; Israeli military says troops searching for suspects; four Palestinians and two Israelis killed in Friday's shooting

Reuters  
NABLUS

Israeli settlers attacked Palestinian villages in the occupied West Bank early on Sunday, setting fire to two mosques and scrawling graffiti on buildings, Palestinian officials said.

The attacks followed an incident on Friday when four Palestinians and two Israeli soldiers were killed when a crowd of Israeli settlers approached the Palestinian village of Tal, southwest of Nablus. During the incident, villagers came out of their homes to confront the settlers and a stand-off ensued.

Palestinian local author-



A Palestinian man prepares to pray at a mosque burned by Israeli settlers in Qusra, in Israeli-occupied West Bank, on Sunday. AFP

ities say the settlers provoked the violence. The Israeli military said shots were fired by both sides.

Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, facing an election in October, or-

dered a security operation against what he described as terrorism against Israeli civilians, reinforcing units in the West Bank.

In an apparent reaction to the deaths of the Isra-

elis, settlers carried out a series of attacks on Palestinian villages in West Bank. Abdel Azim Wadi, head of the village council in Qusra, said settlers had torched a newly completed mosque in his village early on Sunday. "They set it on fire and spray-painted Hebrew slogans on its walls," he said. Among the graffiti were messages including "Jewish revenge".

'Systematic pogroms' The Palestinian Authority, which has responsibility for the section of the West Bank where Friday's shootings took place, said the incident was part of a generalised assault on Palestinians. "Israeli state-

backed settler terrorism is intensifying into systematic pogroms across the occupied West Bank," the Palestinian Prime Minister's office said.

The Israeli military said troops sent to Qusra were searching for suspects. In separate incidents, Palestinian officials said settlers had also tried to burn a mosque near Kour. Farid Jiyousi, a member of the Kour village council, said worshippers had put out the fire before it reached the main area of the mosque.

Most countries and UN consider Israeli settlements in the West Bank illegal, a position Israel rejects.

Iran slams Ukrainian attack on its vessel in Caspian Sea

Agence France-Presse  
TEHRAN

Iran's Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi on Sunday warned that his country would respond to a deadly attack by Ukraine on an Iranian ship in the Caspian Sea.

It came after Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said Kyiv had carried out long-range strikes in the Caspian Sea against vessels transporting military cargo involving Iran, underscoring the increasingly international dimensions of Russia's war in Ukraine.

Sailor killed "Mr. Zelenskyy has attacked an Iranian commercial vessel, killing a sailor," Mr. Araghchi said on social media platform X, describing it as "a blatant UN Char-



Abbas Araghchi

ter violation done at Israel's behest to drag Europe into its war".

He added that, during calls with the European Union's Kaja Kallas and Russian top diplomat Sergei Lavrov, he "made clear that what the free-loader in Kyiv did CANNOT GO UNANSWERED".

Iran's Foreign Ministry said the attack caused the ship "to explode, killing one sailor and injuring sev-

eral others". The Islamic republic "has never intervened in the conflict between Russia and Ukraine", the Ministry said in a statement.

On Saturday, the Ukrainian President said on social media that armed forces had achieved "very strong results with long-range strikes in the Caspian Sea". Ukraine's intelligence services reported on Telegram that drone attacks had been carried out against "cargo vessels under international sanctions that were used to transport military cargo between Iran and Russia".

According to Iranian state television, the Foreign Ministry summoned the Ukrainian charge d'affaires in Tehran on Saturday to protest this "hostile and criminal act".

Russia and Ukraine report civilian deaths as attacks intensify

Agence France-Presse  
KYIV

Russian and Ukrainian strikes killed at least 10 people on Sunday, with Kyiv saying Moscow attacked a supermarket in northern Ukraine and Russia accusing Kyiv of striking a bus stop in the occupied east.

The strikes came a day after 20 people were killed on both sides of the frontline, with both Kyiv and Moscow intensifying attacks while diplomacy to end the war is at a deadlock.

Kyiv said Moscow attacked a supermarket in Chernigiv. "Two people

were killed, including a 10-year-old child," Ukrainian authorities said.

Moscow's strikes killed one person in Zaporizhzhia and another in Kharkiv — where officials said Moscow targeted a residential building.

In Moscow-held Gorlivka, Russian authorities said a Ukrainian drone strike on a bus stop killed four people.

Another person was killed in the occupied part of the Kherson region, Moscow said. Authorities in Russia's Belgorod region said one person was killed by a Ukrainian drone in the village of Smorodino.

Netanyahu fires back at Mamdani and calls ICC charge 'bogus'

Associated Press  
WASHINGTON

Benjamin Netanyahu said on Sunday that New York Mayor Zohran Mamdani is "fomenting hate" by calling the Israeli Prime Minister a war criminal who should be arrested over the war in Gaza if he visits the city for the United Nations General Assembly.

Mr. Netanyahu said he intends to be in New York in September to address the annual U.N. gathering of world leaders.

"He's supposed to be the Mayor of all New Yorkers — Jews, Christians, Muslims, everyone," Mr. Net-

anyahu told Fox News. "But he's trying to turn one group against the other."

Mr. Netanyahu also dismissed the International Criminal Court's war crimes charges against him as "bogus." He pointed to sexual misconduct allegations against Karim Khan, the ICC's top prosecutor, who was removed from that post on Friday, and said the warrant was an attempt to divert attention.

Mr. Mamdani had acknowledged last week that his city did not have the legal authority to arrest Mr. Netanyahu and called on federal authorities to step in.

France, Spain battle 'unpredictable' wildfires as tens of thousands flee

Agence France-Presse  
BORDEAUX

France fought an "unpredictable" wildfire close to Bordeaux on Sunday while Spain warned of "difficult hours" in its own fiery battle, with evacuations from danger zones in both countries mounting to well over 300,000 people.

France's major fire remained unchecked and volatile — driven by gusts that in some cases were generated by the turbulent blazes themselves. Spanish officials, however, voiced optimism they were starting to get a grip on some fires — though on the weekend they were confronted with a new fire front, near Valencia, which forced 15,000 people to flee.

Around 5,000 resi-



On the frontline: Firefighters work as flames burn during a wildfire at Ares, Gironde, in southwestern France on Saturday. REUTERS

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://t.me/+8B98mSPQCfP84MnQ9> Scientists say that such weather emergencies are being made more extreme and frequent by climate change. The disasters came at the peak of the summer vacation period when tourists flock to both countries.

France's Interior Minister Laurent Nunez warned "the situation remains very unfavourable" for fires across the country, where 250,000 people had been evacuated.

The main fire in the southwest Gironde region, where Bordeaux is located, was "extremely intense and unpredictable... generating its own winds and advancing erratically," he said on X.

Some 2,500 firefighters, including a Swiss firefighting team, 1,500 military personnel and around 1,200 police have been deployed to the Gironde region.

One person was killed near Spain's Valencia in a separate, smaller fire. In France, the death toll was two firefighters killed near Bordeaux last week.

कार्यालय नियंत्रक  
शासकीय मुद्रण तथा लेखन सामग्री, म.प्र., भोपाल

क्रमांक 68/42/6/0002/2020/567  
भोपाल, दिनांक 22/07/2026

शासकीय केन्द्रीय मुद्रणालय, भोपाल में स्थापित डिजिटल मशीनों के रखरखाव एवं मशीनों में उपयोग की जाने वाली स्याही, पुर्जे, सेयर पार्ट्स, यूरोपीय, ऑस्ट्रेलियन सिस्टम हेतु तकनीकी विवरण अनुसार आदि पूर्ति करने वाली फर्मों/सेवा प्रदाताओं हेतु MPTDLC विभाग की वेबसाइट [www.mptenders.gov.in](http://www.mptenders.gov.in) में ऑनलाईन की-डेटा अनुसार निविदाएं दिनांक 13-04-2026 को अपरान्ह 12.00 बजे तक आमंत्रित की जाती हैं।

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| NIT No. 05-SAC/2026-27/Raisen                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |                      |          |                |                                                                                                                         |                         |                                     |        |  |  |
| Online Tender for mentioned below are being invited. The Tender have been uploaded on the e-Procurement system of Public Works Department on the Portal <a href="http://www.mptenders.gov.in">www.mptenders.gov.in</a> Tender details are as below:                                                                                                    |                      |          |                |                                                                                                                         |                         |                                     |        |  |  |
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| 1                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | 2                    | 3        | 4              | 5                                                                                                                       | 6                       | 7                                   | 8      |  |  |
| 1                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | 2026_PWDNB_5_22462_1 | Raisen   | BT RENEWAL     | BT RENEWAL WORK OF KHODI JINWOD SHOBHAPUR TIGADA PIPALYA KARKOLA ROAD LENGTH 10.77 KM                                   | 1st                     | 195.90                              |        |  |  |
| 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | 2026_PWDNB_5_22457_1 | Raisen   | BT RENEWAL     | BT RENEWAL WORK OF SULTANGARU TO KHAJURIYA GUSSAI KESHLONE DEBLAPUR NAIGADYA GOPAI ROAD LENGTH 10.62 KM                 | 1st                     | 193.17                              |        |  |  |
| 3                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | 2026_PWDNB_5_22461_1 | Raisen   | BT RENEWAL     | BT RENEWAL WORK OF DUNGARIYA TO PRATAPGARH BABALAYA TOLA KHARERI CHHR PIPARIYA KUCHWARA SEONI KITUA ROAD LENGTH 9.80 KM | 1st                     | 178.25                              |        |  |  |
| 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | 2026_PWDNB_5_22463_1 | Raisen   | BT RENEWAL     | BT RENEWAL WORK OF BADOOYA TO VAGPUR DOOMAR KHAPARIYA KALAN ROAD LENGTH 5.83 KM                                         | 1st                     | 106.04                              |        |  |  |
| 5                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | 2026_PWDNB_5_22467_1 | Raisen   | BT RENEWAL     | BT RENEWAL WORK OF AMAPANI KHURD TO MAIN ROAD TO IMALIYA ROAD LENGTH 5.80 KM                                            | 1st                     | 105.50                              |        |  |  |
| 6                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | 2026_PWDNB_5_22469_1 | Raisen   | BT RENEWAL     | BT RENEWAL WORK OF BAKTARA LAKHANPUR MALJIHR ROAD LENGTH 7.00 KM                                                        | 1st                     | 99.29                               |        |  |  |
| 7                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | 2026_PWDNB_5_22471_1 | Raisen   | BT RENEWAL     | BT RENEWAL WORK OF MEHRAGADON TO HARDOB ROAD LENGTH 4.00 KM                                                             | 1st                     | 72.76                               |        |  |  |
| 8                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | 2026_PWDNB_5_22474_1 | Raisen   | BT RENEWAL     | BT RENEWAL WORK OF BILAKHEDI PARKHEDI GEHUKHEDA MAHARSHI VIDHYA MANDIR TO NH-12 ROAD LENGTH 5.00 KM                     | 1st                     | 70.92                               |        |  |  |
| 9                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | 2026_PWDNB_5_22476_1 | Raisen   | BT RENEWAL     | BT RENEWAL WORK OF MAHALPUR PATTI KISHANPUR DEHGAON JOD ROAD LENGTH 4.89 KM                                             | 1st                     | 69.36                               |        |  |  |
| 10                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     | 2026_PWDNB_5_22478_1 | Raisen   | BT RENEWAL     | BT RENEWAL WORK OF DHOLPUR TO GHOGHRI ROAD LENGTH 4.84 KM                                                               | 1st                     | 65.81                               |        |  |  |
| 11                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     | 2026_PWDNB_5_22479_1 | Raisen   | BT RENEWAL     | BT RENEWAL WORK OF PMGSY AT PANJRA KASHIRAM TO KHERI PRATAPGARH SEMRI KHUBHON ROAD LENGTH 2.86 KM                       | 1st                     | 52.02                               |        |  |  |
| 12                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     | 2026_PWDNB_5_22481_1 | Raisen   | BT RENEWAL     | BT RENEWAL WORK OF KARIYA PATHA TIGADA TO KOLLA ROAD LENGTH 1.80 KM                                                     | 1st                     | 25.53                               |        |  |  |
| 13                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     | 2026_PWDNB_5_22483_1 | Raisen   | REPAIRING      | CULVERT REPAIRING WORK OF VARIOUS ROADS IN SECTION UDAIPURA UNDER SUB DIVISION BARELI                                   | 1st                     | 22.00                               |        |  |  |
| 14                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     | 2026_PWDNB_5_22484_1 | Raisen   | REPAIRING      | CULVERT REPAIRING WORK OF VARIOUS ROADS IN SECTION ALIGANJ UNDER SUB DIVISION BARELI                                    | 1st                     | 21.00                               |        |  |  |
| 15                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     | 2026_PWDNB_5_22486_1 | Raisen   | REPAIRING      | CULVERT REPAIRING WORK OF VARIOUS ROADS IN SECTION KHARGONE UNDER SUB DIVISION BARELI                                   | 1st                     | 21.00                               |        |  |  |
| 16                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     | 2026_PWDNB_5_22487_1 | Raisen   | REPAIRING      | CULVERT REPAIRING WORK OF VARIOUS ROADS IN SECTION DEVERI UNDER SUB DIVISION BARELI                                     | 1st                     | 21.00                               |        |  |  |
| Total                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |                      |          |                |                                                                                                                         |                         | 1319.55                             |        |  |  |
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| 616296/26                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |                      |          |                |                                                                                                                         |                         |                                     |        |  |  |
| Executive Engineer<br>P.W.D. Division Raisen                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |                      |          |                |                                                                                                                         |                         |                                     |        |  |  |



## Sport

## ALL CLEAR

**Gymnast Langton discharged from hospital after a nasty fall**

REUTERS

England's Gabriel Langton was discharged from hospital after scans revealed no lasting damage from a fall which temporarily halted the Commonwealth Games men's team final in Glasgow. Langton landed awkwardly, head first, off the high bar in the final apparatus of Friday's final. The competition was held up for 20 minutes.

## PROUD SKIPPER

**'The young bunch of players have been showing tremendous energy'**

BCCI

India captain Shreyas Iyer described his maiden T20 series win as skipper as a "special moment." "They are a young bunch of players who have been showing tremendous energy on the field. To have such kind of energy is what I require as a captain," said Shreyas after India regained the top spot in the ICC T20I rankings.

## ELITE LIST

**Pogacar bags a record-equalling fifth Tour de France title**

AFP

Tadej Pogacar clinched a record-equalling fifth Tour de France title on Sunday after safely completing the final stage, won by Mathieu van der Poel. The Slovenian joins Jacques Anquetil, Eddy Merckx, Bernard Hinault and Miguel Indurain in an elite list. It was the 27-year-old Pogacar's third straight triumph.

## FIGHTING KNOCKS

**Hodge, Hope help West Indies post 311 in the first innings**

AFP

Skipper Shai Hope's 92 and a knock of 84 by Kaveem Hodge helped West Indies make 311 in the first innings against Pakistan on the second day of the first Test at Tarouba in Trinidad on Sunday. **Scores:** West Indies 311 in 98.5 overs (Hodge 84, Hope 92, Mohammed Ali 4/50) vs Pakistan. **Toss:** West Indies.

## Mirabai completes a hat-trick of gold as records tumble

The Indian weightlifting star rules the roost in women's 48kg; another Manipuri, Rishikanta, bags silver in men's 60kg

## C'WEALTH GAMES

**K. Keerthivasan**  
GLASGOW

As a glowing Mirabai Channu walked into the mixed zone to meet the Indian media here on Sunday, she was in high spirits. So much so that when the cameramen bent down on their knees to fix their microphones, she smiled and said: "Merz Ashirwad (My blessings)! Please finish quickly as I have not eaten for the last few days!"

Mirabai was the darling of the packed gathering at the Scottish Event Campus during the Games.

Going for her third successive Commonwealth Games gold medal, the 31-year-old Indian weightlifting star broke records in both snatch and clean and jerk with ease.

## Huge cheer

The gathering gave her a rousing reception after she completed her lifts and secured gold in women's 48kg with a record 190kg (85 & 105).

"I am very happy that I was able to get my third gold for India," she said.

Mirabai revealed that



All smiles: Mirabai triumphed with ease while Rishikanta overcame knee pain to finish second. ANI & PTI  
Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+8389km5PQC84MnQ9  
There was a lot of pressure on her and she was delighted to handle it. "A lot was going on in my mind - whether I would be able to win the medal this time. I am relieved," she said. Mirabai added that maintain-

ing the 48kg category had been a difficult task. "This performance is very important for me because I

have been controlling my body weight for a long time. It was very difficult for me to bring it down to 48kg. From now on, I will focus on the Asian Games."

It was an emotional moment for another Manipuri weightlifter Rishikanta Singh Chanabam, too. Winning a medal was a "dream-come-true" for the 28-year-old as he claimed silver in men's 60kg with a total of 264kg (a Games record 121kg in snatch and 143 in clean and jerk).

"It's a dream to win my first Commonwealth medal. My family will be very happy," said Rishikanta. He is the first male weightlifter from the State to win a medal at the Games.

## Other Indian results:

**Boxing: Women: 54kg:** Preeti Panwar bt Deborah Mtenje (Malawi) RSC, enters quarterfinals; **Men: 55kg:** Jadumani Singh bt Sumama Rehman (Pak) 5-0, makes it to last eight.

**Lawn bowls: Women's pairs:** Pinki Singh & Rupa Rani Turkey lost to Amy Pharoah & Sian Honnor (Eng) in tie-breaks; **Men:** Pinki & Rupa lost to Amanda Steenkamp & Diana Viljoen (Nam) in tie-break; **Men:** Putul Sonowal lost to Shaun James (Mit) 0.5-1.5.

**Swimming: Men's 4x200m freestyle relay team** (Dhakshan Shashikumar, Aneesh Gowda, Ayman Nehra and Srihari Nataraj), qualified for final.

## Neeraj delighted to be back at CWG where it all began

**K. Keerthivasan**  
GLASGOW

With shoulder-length hair and nothing of the global fame he enjoys today, Neeraj Chopra made his Commonwealth Games debut as a 20-year-old at the 2018 Gold Coast edition.

Much has changed since then. Neeraj, who had won a gold then, has since gone on to become an Olympic gold medalist, World champion and two-time Asian Games champion, establishing himself as one of the biggest names in world athletics.

Now back at the Commonwealth Games after missing the 2022 Birmingham edition because of injury, the 28-year-old said he was delighted to return to an event that holds special memories.

"I have very good memories of the Commonwealth Games. It was my first senior Games competition. I started my career at the Commonwealth Games when I won a gold. I am happy that I am back on the field and feeling good," Neeraj told reporters here on Sunday.

Returning from an eight-month lay-off, Neeraj made his comeback at the Doha Diamond League in June, where he finished fourth with a best throw of 85.69m.

Since competing in Do-



Charged up: Neeraj is eyeing his second gold at CWG. PTI

ha, Neeraj said he has worked on his fitness and technique. "I have worked on my weaknesses and on my fitness. I feel much better now," he said.

Neeraj admitted that the weather conditions would be challenging but insisted they were the same for everyone and that athletes simply had to adjust.

"Yes, I was training the other day. The conditions are tough, but they are the same for everyone. No matter how bad the conditions are, we have to stay mentally strong. I will have to give my 100 per cent," he said.

Javelin throw has become intensely competitive in South Asia, with fel-

low Indians Rohit Yadav and Yashvir Singh, Pakistan's Arshad Nadeem and Sri Lanka's Rumesh Tharanga Pathirane in the fray. Neeraj said it's a welcome rivalry.

"When the competition is tough, we are able to push each other more. That's a good thing, especially as there is a lot of competition in South Asia," he said.

Neeraj appears ready for the challenge, and the men's javelin throw on July 30 and 31 could well provide an indication of his current form and the direction his career is taking.

The athletics event will begin at the Scotstoun Stadium on Monday.

## Sooryavanshi sparkles in India's clean sweep against Zimbabwe

## INDIA IN ZIMBABWE

**Agence France-Presse**  
HARARE

Teenage sensation Vaibhav Sooryavanshi scored his second half-century in four days as India beat Zimbabwe by 35 runs on Sunday for a 3-0 Twenty20 International series sweep.

India won the toss and posted 192 for five at the Harare Sports Club, led by a quickfire 81 from Sooryavanshi. He faced 49 balls and hit eight fours and four sixes.

Zimbabwe reached 157 for seven in reply, thanks mainly to an unbeaten 54 from lower-order batter Ryan Burl (43b, 54x).

Victory marked an Indian turnaround after a 2-0 T20I series loss in Ireland and a 4-0 drubbing in England. It was the second straight series loss for Zimbabwe after going down 2-1 to Bangladesh.

The 15-year-old Sooryavanshi has had a memorable tour of Zimbabwe. He scored his maiden T20I half-century off just 18 balls in the first match and followed it up with 20 off nine deliveries in the second.

The left-hander made

his intentions clear from the first ball. He launched the Indian innings with a four off Zimbabwe captain and all-rounder Sikandar Raza and reached 50 off 31 balls. He fell off the final ball of the 15th over. Sooryavanshi got out to Wessly Madhevere when Brad Evans dashed from the ropes to long off and caught the ball.

Zimbabwe slumped to 65 for four in reply with opener Brian Bennett and Raza both dismissed for golden ducks. The high-light of the innings was the 60-run fifth-wicket stand between Burl and Madhevere (28).

## SCOREBOARD

**INDIA**  
Vaibhav Sooryavanshi c Evans b Madhevere 81 (49b, 8x4, 4x6), Abhishek Sharma c Marumani b Muzarabani 2 (4b), Ishan Kishan b Sikandar 29 (26b, 4x4), Shreyas Iyer c Madhevere b Evans 27 (18b, 2x4), Tilak Varma (not out) 11 (9b, 1x4), Rinku Singh c Madhevere b Evans 25 (14b, 2x4, 1x6), Madhevere b Evans (b-1, lb-1, w-15) 17; Total (for five wkts. in 20 overs): 192.

**FALL OF WICKETS**  
1-20 (Abhishek, 1.5 overs), 2-95 (Kishan, 10.1), 3-145 (Sooryavanshi, 14.6), 4-164 (Shreyas, 17.1), 5-192 (Rinku, 19.6).



Take that! Sooryavanshi gave another exhibition of his prodigious talent. BCCI

**ZIMBABWE BOWLING**  
Sikandar 0 (1b), Ben Curran c Mayank b Bishnoi 20 (19b, 2x4), Dion Myers c Shreyas b Yash Thakur 19 (15b, 1x4, 1x6), Sikandar Raza c & b Yash Thakur 0 (1b), Ryan Burl (not out) 54 (42b, 5x4), Wessly Madhevere c Tilak b Mayank 28 (25b, 1x4, 2x6), Tadiwanashe Marumani b Ashok 1 (3b), Brad Evans c Rinku b

Mayank 14 (13b, 1x6), Newman Nyamhuri (not out) 1 (1b); Extras (b-4, lb-2, nb-1, w-13) 20; Total (for seven wkts. in 20 overs): 157.

**FALL OF WICKETS**  
1-0 (Bennett, 0.1), 2-34 (Myers, 3.4), 3-34 (Sikandar, 3.5), 4-65 (Curran, 7.2), 5-125 (Madhevere, 15.4), 6-134 (Marumani, 17.1), 7-156 (Evans, 19.5).

**INDIA BOWLING**  
Mayank 4-0-29-3, Yash Thakur 4-0-45-2, Ashok 4-0-20-1, Bishnoi 4-0-24-1, Shedge 2-0-15-0, Abhishek 2-0-18-0.

**Toss:** India; **Pol & Pos:** Sooryavanshi; India won by 35 runs to clinch series 3-0.

## U Mumba's UTT reign continues

**Amol Karhadkar**  
PANAJI

Defending champion U Mumba TT snapped Demop Goia Challengers' unbeaten run to retain the Ultimate Table Tennis crown with a 8-5 victory in the Season-7 final at the Dr. Shyama Prasad Mukherjee Indoor Stadium on Sunday.

The summit clash ebbed and flowed before U Mumba's superior depth and composure proved decisive.

Goa made a bright start through teenager P.B. Abhinand, who unsettled Frenchman Lillian Bardet once again with his unconventional style built around a long-pimped backhand rubber. Although he couldn't replicate his 3-0 demolition from the tournament opener, Abhinand repeatedly disrupted the Frenchman's rhythm before Bardet finally found his range with a flurry of forehand winners in the third game to put U Mumba on the board.

World No.24 Bernadette Soez then showcased why she remains one of the world's elite. Locked in a high-quality contest against World No. 34 Anna Hursay, she trailed 4-6 after dropping the opening game before reeling off six



On cloud nine: The U Mumba players and staff exult after going the distance. BUTTERFLY UTT

consecutive points to wrest control and restore Goa's advantage.

Leading 4-2 after two singles, Challengers looked set to tighten the grip. Instead, Manush Shah changed the complexion of the final. The bespectacled Indian combined superbly with Hursay to blank Alvaro Robles and Syndrela Das in mixed doubles, silencing a partisan crowd of over 1,200 and drawing U Mumba level.

The all-left-hander duel between Manush and Robles lived up to expectations, with both players producing breathtaking forehand and backhand top-spin exchanges.

The rally of the evening came at 6-6 in the opening

game, Robles finishing a 13-shot exchange with a stunning forehand sidespin winner from well behind the table before stringing together four straight points to take the game.

Manush responded in style. Trailing 9-10 in the second, he produced a full-stretch forehand topspin winner to force a golden point, where Robles missed an ambitious third-ball attack. Buoyed by the escape, Manush quickened the tempo in the decider, forcing a string of unforced errors to put U Mumba on the verge.

With U Mumba leading 7-5 and needing only one more game, Anusha Kutumbale, preferred ahead of Nithyashree Mani, kept

her composure against teen sensation Syndrela Das. While Syndrela was forced into an all-out attacking approach in pursuit of three straight games, Anusha played percentage table tennis throughout. Syndrela saved two championship points to force a golden point but miscued a high ball, handing U Mumba the top prize.

**The results: Final: U Mumba TT bt Demop Goia Challengers 8-5** (Lilian Bardet lost to P.B. Abhinand 7-11, 9-11, 11-6; Anna Hursay lost to Bernadette Soez 11-5, 7-11, 7-11; Manush Shah & Hursay bt Alvaro Robles & Syndrela Das 11-8, 11-7, 11-9; Manush bt Robles 6-11, 11-10, 11-5; Anusha Kutumbale bt Syndrela Das 11-10).

A NO-IDE







P.K. Ajith Kumar

Sophie Devine stopped kindly for her fans. She smiled into the selfie camera. She engaged for a while with the cricket fans, who had assembled in large numbers on that warm Sunday afternoon at Lord's for the Women's T20 World Cup match between India and Australia.

Devine's World Cup had been over by then: New Zealand had been knocked out of the Women's T20 World Cup.

She had announced that she would be quitting international cricket after the World Cup. Suzie Bates and Lea Tahuhu, who along with Devine were the members of the New Zealand team that won the last T20 World Cup in UAE two years ago, had also played their last matches for White Ferns.

It was as if these magnificent women, who between them played 894 games for New Zealand, were making the opening statement for what would be a summer of farewells in cricket. Their countryman Kane Williamson ended his international career during the Test series in England, which overlapped with the Women's World Cup. And there were more to follow: Ben Stokes, Heather Knight, Tammy Beaumont.

Rarely has cricket seen so many stars leaving the stage within a space of so little time. We also saw the curtain coming down on two high-profile coaching stints: of Brendon McCullum and Stephen Fleming. As if all that wasn't enough, Garry Sobers, cricket's greatest all-rounder of all time, bid an even more poignant farewell.

Devine, a quality all-rounder, has been one of the most feared batters in women's cricket. Those who watched her make 99 off just 36 balls for Royal Challengers Bengaluru against Gujarat Titans at the Brabourne Stadium in the inaugural Women's Premier League in 2023 were fortunate. It was the McCullum moment of the WPL. And McCullum, whose stunning hundred for Kolkata Knight Riders against RCB in the first ever match of the IPL set the tone for the world's most glamorous cricket league, had been the biggest influence on her, she had told this correspondent in an interview.

**Sense of humour, and purpose**  
International women's cricket will certainly miss those big hits from Devine.

Her sense of humour will be missed as much. Her interviews and press conferences have been fun. After her sensational innings against KKR, when Devine was asked about her going after Australian all-rounder Ashleigh Gardner (24 runs in the second over of the innings), she smiled: "She has been a bully to a lot of other people over the years and I think it is only fair that she has got a bit of her own back."

Like Gardner, many bowlers have been at the receiving end of the might of Devine's bat over the last decade and a half, during which she scored 8096 runs and 241 wickets for New Zealand.

In 2020, she became the first player - man or woman - to hit six fifty-plus scores in T20Is. She had also represented New Zealand in hockey.

Bates had made her debut for New Zealand seven months before Devine. She too was a double international, having played basketball for her country. She, in fact, represented New Zealand at the 2008 Olympics in Beijing.

Bates has finished her international career with 4758 runs in T20Is, more than any other batter, male or female. She also scored 5982 runs in ODIs, with 13 hundreds. But it hadn't been easy for her, like other players of her generation, when women's cricket wasn't anywhere near as popular as it is today.

"When I was young, from 18 to 24, I studied, and we got grants from the government to study and play sports to help pay for our living allowances," Bates had once said in an interview to *The Hindu*. "I took part-time roles like coaching, whether it was basketball, cricket, to earn a little bit of money on the side, and when we were away, we got reimbursed."

If things are much easier for the women cricketers of today, they owe it to players like Bates, Devine and Tahuhu, the seamer who finished her international career with 225 wickets for New Zealand.

**Remarkable transformation**

Knight and Beaumont, too, have been fortunate that they could be part of the remarkable transformation the game has undergone since they debuted for England. Women's cricket has changed so much that Knight could see her own image staring at her from all over London - at tube and bus stations and at Lord's - this English summer, thanks to the MCC's catchy campaign to promote the historic England-India Women's Test.

She and Beaumont were indeed lucky that they could end their international careers with the first ever Test match for women at Lord's. That was the 15th Test for Knight, who played 160 ODIs and 145 T20Is. She had led England to the 2017 World Cup victory at home. She was a

# Cricket's summer of goodbyes

Rarely has the sport seen so many stars leaving the stage within a space of so little time. We also saw the curtain coming down on two high-profile coaching stints: of Brendon McCullum and Stephen Fleming. As if all that wasn't enough, Garry Sobers, cricket's greatest all-rounder of all-time, bid an even more poignant farewell



**Signing off:** Devine, Tahuhu, Bates, McCullum, Stokes, Williamson, Fleming, Beaumont and Knight. GETTY IMAGES & K. MURALI KUMAR

batter that England could bank on.

Runs flowed freely from Beaumont's bat too, during her 17-year career, in which she scored 12 hundreds and 24 fifties in ODIs. She also became the first ever woman to score a Test double hundred.

If England's women's team lost two of their best batters, the men's team had to say goodbye to its inspiring captain, all-rounder extraordinaire and miracle-worker. Stokes is easily one of the most gifted cricketers of his generation and will go down in history as one of the game's all-time greats. With two incredible innings in 2019, he won England a World Cup and an Ashes Test victory for ages.

He was also the ideal captain to implement McCullum's brave ideas to transform England's Test fortunes. While the verdict on Bazball may not be unanimous, the fact remains that Stokes and McCullum brought a new dimension to Test match cricket.

**The complete package**

Stokes will be remembered as one of the most complete cricketers: he was brilliant as a batter, bowler and fielder. Yes, his career was hampered by injuries and a few incidents outside the field that he may not like to remember. But, few cricketers in our time have given the game as many exciting moments on the field. Williamson has undoubtedly been one of the greatest batters of his generation, a part of the Fab Four alongside Joe Root, Steve Smith and Virat Kohli. He was fabulous across formats. He finished his international career with 9515 runs in Tests at an average of 54.06, 7256

in ODIs at 48.69, 2575 in T20Is at 33.44. And he hit 48 international hundreds.

He also led New Zealand admirably. Fittingly, he was the captain when the Kiwis won the inaugural World Test Championship, after beating India in the final. He has been admired not just for being a run-machine, but for his genial nature as well.

It was from McCullum that Williamson had taken over the New Zealand captaincy. That was in 2016. Some three years later, McCullum turned to coaching with Trinbago Knight Riders and Kolkata Knight Riders.

Then in 2022, he was appointed as England's coach. That would prove to be perhaps the most discussed coaching job in cricket's history. McCullum's ultra-aggressive approach to playing Test cricket, called Bazball, gave England some great Test wins, but some chastening defeats too. Bazball had begun on a stunning note, with England notching up four magnificent against in a row at home - three against New Zealand and one against India. Some of the innings the England batters played, under McCullum, by the likes of Jonny Bairstow, Ollie Pope and Ben Duckett, were spectacular.

**Sport's greatest theatre**

But Test cricket is no extension of T20 cricket. It is sport's greatest theatre, and the most challenging mode of all sports. That is why we all love it.

You cannot Bazball your way out of trouble all the time. It was bound to fail at some points of time. And it failed spectacularly in the difficult conditions of India and Australia. Finally, McCullum had to go, after the defeat to New Zealand



**Sir Gary!** Sobers, the undisputed king of cricket. GETTY IMAGES

in the home series.

But, he had shown a new way to play Test cricket. That will not be forgotten.

The other high-profile Kiwi coach's departure too was perhaps as inevitable. Fleming's association had been, however, much longer, and he had become one of the faces of Chennai Super Kings. He became the CSK coach in 2009 and the following year, he led the franchise to the IPL title. He helped CSK triumph again in 2011, 2018, 2021 and 2023.

He was in Chennai all along, except in 2016 and 2017 when he moved to Rising Pune Supergiant following CSK's two-year suspension. Fleming's at CSK had one of the IPL's most successful coaching careers.

There was no IPL in Sobers' time. Even the ODIs arrived a bit too late for him (he played just one). He would have been T20 cricket's biggest superstar.

Cricketer's most versatile player, who scored 8032 runs at an average of 57.78 and took 235 wickets from 93 Tests, passed away on July 17 at the age of 89.

## THE GIST

Williamson ended his international career during the Test series in England, which overlapped with the Women's World Cup

McCullum, with Bazball, had shown a new way to play Test cricket. The other Kiwi coach's departure too was perhaps as inevitable. Fleming's association had been, however, much longer, and he had become one of the faces of Chennai Super Kings

If things are much easier for the women cricketers of today, they owe it to players like Bates, Devine and Tahuhu



## SCIENCE

# India's first dengue vaccine arrives with a crucial safety caveat

Qdenga could be responsible for enhancing dengue in children who have not had an infection yet in their lives; in such cases, the vaccine could simulate a primary dengue infection in the body, resulting in protection against DENV-1 and DENV-2 infections but not against a DENV-3 infection

Swaminathan S

India's drug regulator just approved the country's first dengue vaccine, Qdenga. It is designed and claimed to protect against the four serotypes of the dengue-causing virus, called DENV-1 to DENV-4. Young children as well as adults (aged 4-60 years), irrespective of whether they have had dengue before, may be vaccinated with Qdenga.

More than 40 countries have already approved Qdenga, which is manufactured by the Japanese pharmaceutical company Takeda. That said, data from clinical trials that Takeda published in 2019, 2020, and 2024 on the vaccine's efficacy raise a specific concern about its abilities.

## Rationale of dengue vaccines

All the four DENV serotypes are prevalent in India. Each serotype is different from the other such that an immune response to one may not necessarily protect against another. A person who has experienced a natural dengue infection will carry antibodies to the specific DENV serotype in their serum, and the person will be said to be seropositive. A person who has not been exposed to a natural DENV infection will not carry dengue antibodies and is said to be seronegative.

When a seronegative person contracts a first DENV infection for the first time, they will develop antibodies to that particular DENV serotype. When this person, seropositive for that particular DENV serotype, suffers a second infection by another DENV serotype, there is a non-zero chance that they may experience severe dengue. This is because the antibodies produced against the first DENV serotype may actually enhance infection by the second DENV serotype. This is called antibody-dependent enhancement (ADE).

The holy grail of dengue vaccines is to avoid ADE. Any safe and effective vaccine for dengue must be 'tetravalent' — meaning it must target all four DENV serotypes simultaneously and equally. If a dengue vaccine fails to protect against even one serotype, it will keep the door open to ADE in future.

It is quite clear that the efficacy and safety of a dengue vaccine are linked to each other as two sides of the same coin. And Qdenga's phase-3 trial efficacy data need to be understood through this lens.

## Phase-3 trial

Takeda set up a large phase-3 trial involving around 20,000 healthy children (4-16 years old) across eight Latin American and Asian countries where dengue is endemic to assess Qdenga's safety and efficacy. The results from this trial were first published in 2019, with additional data published in 2020 and

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The efficacy and safety of a dengue vaccine are linked to each other as two sides of the same coin, and Qdenga's phase-3 trial data need to be understood through this lens. GETTY IMAGES

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>

2024. Around two-thirds of the children in the trial received Qdenga while the remaining third received a saline solution. Then the researchers compared the vaccine efficacy between the two groups. The efficacy was defined to mean the ability of Qdenga to prevent dengue infections and resultant hospitalisation.

If the vaccine worked as intended, one would expect fewer cases of dengue in the vaccinated group versus in the unvaccinated group. And this was true. In the vaccinated group, five children out of 1,000 contracted a DENV infection while in the unvaccinated group, 24 children per 1,000 contracted a DENV infection. This translates to an overall efficacy of about 80%.

Overall, Takeda's investigators stratified their participants into seropositive and seronegative groups before administering the vaccine. The efficacy was about 82% and 75% in these two groups, respectively. These seem like solid numbers — but the devil is in the details.

## 'Variable VE'

If you look at the results stratified by DENV serotype as well, a particular granular detail, which could actually be a potential safety signal, emerges. In children who were seronegative prior to vaccination, those susceptible to DENV-3 infection were noticeably more numerous in the vaccinated group than in the unvaccinated group. In other words, seronegative children vaccinated with

**The consequences of contracting a secondary DENV-4 infection by seronegative children cannot be predicted since we do not know of Qdenga's efficacy against DENV-4: in India, the number of such children facing this risk could be very large**

Qdenga were 25% more likely to be infected by DENV-3 relative to unvaccinated children.

The number of DENV-4 cases during the trial were so low (in the seropositive group) or totally absent (in the seronegative group) that the efficacy of Qdenga for DENV-4 is essentially unknown. The efficacy was high against DENV-1 and -2, irrespective of the serostatus at baseline.

The investigators had consistently noted these observations in Takeda's 2020 and 2024 papers as well.

They also persistently referred to this feature of their vaccine as "variable VE against the different serotypes" and described it as a "numerical imbalance" in the number of dengue infections.

The data clearly demonstrate that Qdenga does not offer protection against DENV-3 and could in fact actually be responsible for enhancing dengue in children who have not had a dengue infection yet in their lives. In such cases, Qdenga — being a live dengue vaccine — could simulate a primary dengue

infection in the body, resulting in protection against DENV-1 and DENV-2 infections — but not against a DENV-3 infection.

And if such children were to contract a natural DENV-3 infection, they will have a 25% higher likelihood of falling sick, as this will be a secondary dengue infection linked to potential ADE.

## Need for screening

The consequences of contracting a secondary DENV-4 infection by such children cannot be predicted since we do not know of Qdenga's efficacy against DENV-4. At a conservative estimate of 40 million children in India, with only under 30% of them estimated to be seropositive for dengue, the number of seronegative children facing this heightened risk could be very large.

In a paper in *Nature Medicine* on July 25, researchers from Imperial College London modelled the health impact of Qdenga in a population and concluded that it would be safer for seronegative recipients — especially children — to be screened for prior dengue exposure before receiving the shot.

In sum, ignoring the DENV-3 safety signal in seronegative children could be a costly and avoidable mistake, and should be avoided through screening.

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## THE GIST

Qdenga is designed and claimed to protect against the four serotypes of the dengue-causing virus, called DENV-1 to DENV-4

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## BIG SHOT



Experts from the Indira Gandhi National Centre for the Arts use a portable X-ray fluorescence analyser to examine the pigments, material composition and condition of centuries-old frescoes during their scientific documentation and conservation at Amer Fort, in Jaipur, Rajasthan, on July 24. PTI

## WHAT IS IT?

# PRAXIS: grazing planet rings

Vasudevan Mukunth

PRAXIS is an acronym of 'Planetary Rings Autonomous Exploration with In-situ Sampling'. NASA has just selected a mission concept called 'PRAXIS' for its Innovative Advanced Concepts (NIAC) 2026 phase I funding. The mission will consist of a bio-inspired robotic explorer driven by an artificial intelligence (AI) model. It will be capable of directly sampling particles from planetary ring systems — something no mission has ever attempted before. The mission's selection for NIAC was guided by open questions in the science of planets' rings that NASA's Planetary Science Decadal Survey has flagged as important.

These questions include how planetary rings form, how they evolve, and what ring particles are made of. Rather than fly through a ring — which would pose collision hazards — PRAXIS currently plans to just graze the ring plane. Specifically, once it has picked a target particle, the spacecraft will perform a touch-and-go sample of the particle's surface using a long deployable boom, staying at a safe distance from the moving ring particles. Once it has a sample, the craft will move on to another region or gap in the rings to sample from another area. When it has a sample, small instruments will snag free-floating particles and the



James Webb Space Telescope's view of Saturn's atmosphere. SPACE TELESCOPE SCIENCE INSTITUTE/NASA

AI model will help measure particle size, porosity, and composition. Being selected for NIAC phase-I finding means the PRAXIS team can start running simulations and studying system design. If the idea advances to phase II, the team can start building a physical prototype. According to its developers, the PRAXIS sampling mission can be used in missions to study many ringed planets.

For feedback and suggestions for 'Science', please write to [science@thehindu.co.in](mailto:science@thehindu.co.in) with the subject 'Daily page'